My Chimera Can’t Possibly Be This Cute!
Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at
http://archiveofourown.org/works/69934906.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail), Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Accidental Bonding, Phainon is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Jealous Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Comedy, Banter, Confessions, Domestic Fluff, accidental pet acquisition, Mydei is So Done (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon is Bad at Feelings (Honkai: Star Rail), Kind of Embarrassing for Phainon Actually

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-08-28 Words: 20,615 Chapters: 1/1

My Chimera Can’t Possibly Be This Cute!

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon sets out to find Mydei. What he actually finds is a pocket-sized chimera he falls head over heels in love with and naturally names Snowy. What follows is a suspicious amount of cooing, dubiously safe bonding activities, a minor head injury, and the creeping suspicion that maybe he’s been looking at the wrong place all along.

(At least Snowy was cute.)

Notes

Late as hell both in terms of post and time rn. Well for one this was meant to be done a week ago but I got busy, and two I’m fighting demons rn not to go to sleep while editing this so pls point out any mistakes you see guys😭

Oh yeah also got the idea from @evilsybs from Twitter, check them out!

AND I FORGOT TO ADD THIS BUT CHECK OUT THIS WONDERFUL ART <333!!!

See the end of the work for more notes

It was a beautiful day today.

The Marmoreal Market was loud in the way only markets could be—half arguments, half laughter, all of it stitched together with the smells of spice, fruit, and sweat. Stalls spilled over with wares: baskets of figs, pyramids of olives, silks fluttering like banners in the breeze.

Phainon was in the thick of it, leaning on the counter of a stall piled high with pomegranates, their skins glowing like rubies in the sun.

“You’re robbing me,” he accused the vendor, twirling one in his hand like it was a coin. “Don’t think I don’t notice.”

The woman scoffed, rolling her eyes as she adjusted a basket. “Robbing you? Please. These beauties are worth every coin. You want cheap fruit, go find yourself a Dromas’s feed.”

Phainon sighed heavily, shoulders slumping. “Redsoil wouldn’t look half as good on my table. Or taste half as sweet. You’ve cornered me, haven’t you?”

“Glad you noticed,” she said with a grin.

That earned a giggle from her daughter, who was peeking out from behind her skirts. Phainon leaned down gently, whispering just loud enough for the girl to hear. “Between you and me, I think your mother raises the prices just because she knows I’ll still pay.”

The girl nodded solemnly, eyes wide, which set her mother laughing despite herself. She bundled the fruit into a cloth bag and handed it over.

As Phainon reached for it, she said idly, “you know… strange not seeing you two together today.”

He blinked, tilting his head like a curious hound. “Two?”

The vendor hesitated, realizing too late what she’d let slip. “Ah—I only meant… you and your friend.”

Phainon’s smile softened into something more thoughtful. “Mydei?”

She nodded quickly, as though the name alone explained everything. “Yes. That one.”

“Well, you’re right,” Phainon admitted, tucking the bag under his arm. “We were meant to meet an hour ago for our bath session. But when I went looking, he was nowhere. Checked all the usual corners—nothing. So I thought, if he’s hiding, he’s not starving. Might as well fetch some fruit while I wait him out.”

“Your stubborn prince,” she teased, shaking her head.

“Don’t remind me,” Phainon groaned. “The number of times I’ve had to drag him by the wrist into the water… And now the one time he promises to meet me, he disappears. Makes me look ridiculous.”

“You don’t need help with that,” she shot back with a laugh, and waved him off.

Phainon saluted with two fingers and let himself be carried back into the tide of the market. His smile lingered, but his thoughts drifted. Mydei could sulk with the best of them, yes, but he didn’t break promises—not even small ones.

Still, he shook his head, pushing it aside for now. He let his gaze wander as he strolled, watching a pair of kids chase each other through the crowd, passing a performer who dropped a knife and cursed loudly enough to earn applause. Life thrummed in every corner.

That was when he heard it: a faint shuffle near a stack of clay craters piled against a wall. Small. Easy to miss in the noise. But Phainon’s ears pricked at the sound the way a dog perks at a half-heard whistle.

He slowed, adjusting the bag of fruit as if that were his only concern, though his eyes slid toward the stack. Odd. Craters shifted all the time here—merchants, elbows, kids hiding where they shouldn’t. Nothing unusual.

And yet.

The way it went quiet afterward…

He rocked back on his heels, debating with himself. Curiosity was rarely his best trait. But it was always his loudest.

So, after a beat, he drifted a little closer to the stack of craters. Not directly—he wasn't about to look like some nosy fool poking around jars—but enough that he could catch another sound if it came.

At first, nothing.

And then—there. A faint scrape against clay. The smallest shuffle.

Phainon's eyes narrowed.

Something flicked at the edge of the stack—oh? He leaned ever so slightly, squinting through the slant of sunlight.

Was that… a tail?

It slipped out for half a heartbeat, swayed once, and then vanished again as if the creature knew it had been seen.

Phainon stopped dead. "…Huh."

Well, it was definitely not a Dromas—that much was certain. Dromas tails were long and hard to miss, especially attached to a creature the size of a tower beam. And cats… no, it wasn't quite right for a cat either. The tuft at the end was all wrong.

His mouth pulled into an incredulous half-smile. "Don't tell me… a chimera?"

Now that was odd. Plenty of them wandered Okhema, sure, but here? In the middle of the market, tucked behind cheap clay jars? That wasn't exactly where you expected to find one lazing about.

He tapped the pomegranate bag against his leg, considering.

His gaze drifted left, toward the wide steps of Marmoreal Diner. It wasn't far—barely a minute's walk. The warm scent of meat and cumin was already curling through the air, teasing his stomach. Whatever was behind those craters wasn't going anywhere fast. It would either hunker down or make a run for it, and if it ran, well… he'd notice.

He stretched his arms overhead in a lazy yawn, shook himself loose, and muttered, "Might as well."

With that, he turned into the current of the crowd, letting himself be carried toward the diner.

The Marmoreal Diner looked the same as always—open and humming with life. Clay cups clattered, a few merchants nursed steaming drinks over their ledgers, the scent of flatbread baking on hot stone made the whole place feel warmer than it already was.

Nearby, Kyros was finishing up with an older woman, sliding a small dish into her hands. She offered a grateful nod before making her way towards a seat.

When Kyros's gaze lifted and caught sight of him, his brows arched just slightly. "Ah—Lord Phainon. To what do I owe the pleasure?"

Phainon raised a hand in easy greeting. "Come on, no need for titles now. You'll scare off the regulars."

That earned him a faint twitch of a smile. "Then let me say—Phainon. You're a rarer guest at this hour. What brings you in?"

"Curiosity," Phainon said, dropping the pomegranates onto the counter with a light thud. "And maybe hunger. Mostly hunger."

Kyros inclined his head, folding his hands neatly in front of him. "Well, one usually follows the other."

Phainon leaned against the counter, comfortable, the way he always did here. He liked talking with Kyros, liked the way conversations slipped between food and history. He wasn't any good at lessons in a formal setting, but here, with the smell of roasting meat and spiced bread? He remembered things.

"You've already walked me through the spice routes," he said, tapping his chin in mock thought. "And pottery traditions. And—what was it—the meaning behind Kephale's signature?"

"Creation marked in the shape of a handprint," Kyros replied evenly. "Though I seem to recall you mistaking it for a cooking diagram."

Phainon barked out a laugh, sheepish as he rubbed the back of his neck. "Alright, fair. Not my brightest moment."

"Imagine my surprise," Kyros said dryly, though his tone carried just enough lightheartedness to make it teasing rather than cutting.

They shared a chuckle, the noise mingling with the murmur of the diner.

"Anyway," he said at last, straightening a bit. "I'm not here to waste your time with questions today. Just figured I'd ask if you had something simple. Lamb skewers, maybe?"

Kyros inclined his head once. "Of course. Just a moment."

And with practiced calm, he slipped into the kitchen, the curtain swinging shut behind him.

Left alone at the counter, Phainon propped his bag of fruit within reach and exhaled. He closed his eyes briefly, letting the warmth and the scent of spiced meat wash over him. His stomach was already halfway to satisfied just from the smell.

But his mind… his mind drifted back to the market.

Back to that flick of a tail.

Kyros, true to form, hadn’t kept him waiting long. Before Phainon knew it, the skewers were wrapped and ready. He had tried, in a moment of guilt, to slip a little extra, but one firm look from Kyros had made him think better.

So he left with dinner in hand, lighter in step than before, the skewers still warm against his palm.

Back to the craters. Back to the little tail.

He half-smiled as he threaded through the market, humming under his breath. If the creature was still there, well—he had lamb. And lamb had a way of coaxing most things out.

But then—something off.

The usual hum of Marmoreal’s market had a snag in it, like a thread pulled taut. The voices didn’t blur together; they gathered, circled. People slowed, craning necks. A knot of bodies had formed just beyond the next row of stalls.

Phainon’s stride eased into a careful halt. His brow furrowed as he adjusted the skewers in his grip, shifting to one hand so the other stayed free.

He edged closer, slipping between a pair of gawkers.

At first all he saw was a man’s hand slashing through the air in broad gestures, and a woman beside him, dabbing furiously at her sleeve with a handkerchief. Their clothes weren’t torn, not badly—but the way the man carried on, you’d think they’d been mauled.

“Look at this!” the man’s voice cut through the noise. “Ruined—completely ruined! These were new!”

The woman let out a sharp huff. “It scratched me! Wild thing, should’ve been leashed—if it belongs to anyone at all.”

Scratched.

Phainon’s gaze lowered.

There—dark streaks scored across the man’s leg. Fresh. And beyond them, in the little clearing people instinctively gave to trouble, a shape crouched low to the cobblestones.

Small.

Trembling.

Not just trembling—hissing.

Phainon’s chest tightened.

The chimera. The same tail he had glimpsed earlier, now bristling, curled tight. Its flank rose and fell too fast, too shallow. Fur clumped where blood had matted it down. One paw dragged faintly when it shifted, stiff and wrong. And still—it bared its teeth, the tiniest snarl grinding out of it, standing its ground even as the woman’s foot drew back.

The skewers nearly slipped from his hand.

The kick never landed. The chimera lunged first, teeth flashing, sinking into the woman’s calf. She shrieked, skirts tangling as she stumbled back. The little beast wrenched free and bolted, weaving between startled legs until it vanished down an alley.

A thin trail of red dotted the stones behind it.

Phainon stood very still.

The couple, of course, found their voices at once.

“Vicious little pest!” the man exclaimed, dabbing at his leg as if the shallow scratches were mortal wounds. The woman hissed through her teeth, clutching her calf, but she forced a brittle laugh all the same, leaning against him.

“It’s fine, it’s fine—just a scratch. Honestly though, what kind of place is this? Animals running wild—dirtying people’s clothes—someone should do something.”

The man puffed up at that, throwing her a grin meant to charm. “If I’d gotten my hands on it, trust me, it wouldn’t have gotten away. Next time I’ll wring its—”

He didn’t finish.

Because his wrist was no longer his.

A hand had closed around it—not harsh, but with a pressure that made his words stick in his throat.

The man turned, confused—then blanched.

“L—Lord Phainon!”

The name cracked out like a prayer. The woman’s laugh died on her lips.

Phainon stood before them, smile thin. His grip hadn’t even tightened, but the man’s knuckles had already blanched beneath it.

“…Wring what?” Phainon asked.

The man stammered. “I—I didn’t mean—”

“You didn’t mean?” Phainon’s brow arched, voice smooth as glass. “Strange. I could’ve sworn I heard you just fine. Unless you think my ears have gone bad with my eyes.”

The woman swallowed. “We—we were only startled—”

“Startled.” Phainon let out a soft, incredulous laugh. “Startled, so you put your boots into something a tenth your size? That’s your measure of courage?”

The man tugged faintly against his hold. Nothing gave. “It attacked us first —look at her leg, my clothes—”

The brightness left Phainon’s eyes, replaced by something flat.

“You’re worried about your tunic,” he said slowly, “while the creature you struck is bleeding into the street.”

The man’s throat bobbed. The woman’s grip on his arm trembled.

Phainon’s fingers tightened—just enough to wring a hiss of pain from him.

“You want a fight?” The words were colder now. “Find a Titan. Or a titankin. Something that can hit back. Not a half-grown animal you can kick between your errands.”

The man’s face had gone chalk-white, his free hand fluttering uselessly.

Phainon held him there one breath longer—grip merciless. Then, with a scoff, he released him.

“Get out of my sight.”

The man stumbled back immediately, clutching his wrist. The woman tugged at him, eager to vanish into the crowd.

Phainon didn’t watch them go. His eyes had already dropped to the stones —to the faint smears of red leading away.

For a long moment he only stood there, the skewers cooling in his hand.

Then he exhaled, sharp through his nose, and followed the trail.

Fortunately, it wasn’t hard to track the poor thing down.

A faint smear of blood trailed along the cobblestones, like breadcrumbs winding through the narrow alleys. The marks thinned, faltered, but never vanished.

And then, abruptly, the trail ended.

Phainon slowed.

Beneath the lip of an overturned cart, propped crookedly against the wall, two golden eyes glowed from shadow.

The little chimera crouched low, body taut. Its chest rose too fast, shallow, and the angle of its flank against the stone half-concealed the limp it carried.

Phainon let out the breath he'd been holding.

Found you.

He took one step forward.

The chimera's head snapped toward him. Ears flattened. Lips peeled back from small, needle-sharp teeth. A rasping hiss ripped from its throat, vibrating down to its chest.

Phainon stopped, hands open, careful not to spook it further. "…Right. So much for easy."

He crouched low, easing his weight onto one knee. His voice softened automatically, instinctive, the tone he'd used years ago to coax half-wild strays back home. "Easy, buddy. I'm not here to hurt you."

The chimera's growl deepened, vibrating through the walls. But something in its gaze shifted—not the raw cornered fury he expected. It flickered, startled. Almost… offended?

Their eyes met.

And everything in the chimera's snarl stuttered. Its lips faltered, then bared again like it had to *remember* to stay threatening.

Phainon blinked, caught off guard.

The chimera blinked back—once, twice—expression strangely dumbfounded, as if it had just recognized something it shouldn't.

"…Huh," Phainon murmured, tilting his head with a faint smile. "That's quite a face. Lesser men would've bolted."

The chimera's tail lashed once, a sharp snap of indignation, before it growled again.

Phainon huffed a laugh, low. "Yeah, yeah. Don't trust me. Fair."

His hand drifted toward his pocket—then he remembered. The skewers.

He pulled them free slowly, letting the scent of roasted lamb curl through the air.

"Here. I got this for you. You must be hungry, yeah?"

The chimera bristled, but its nose twitched despite itself.

Phainon lowered the skewers to the ground, nudging one gently forward. "No tricks," he coaxed. "Go on. Yours."

Silence stretched. Then the chimera's paw darted out—smack, smack—testing, as if making sure the food was real. When it didn't vanish, it snatched the meat and retreated into shadow.

It ate neatly, almost too neatly for something so injured. Each bite was surprisingly dignified. Every few seconds, its gaze flicked back to him—sharp, assessing, reluctant.

Phainon held the stare, patient. The longer it went on, the stranger it felt.

Until finally, he laughed under his breath, breaking the tension. "You're too damn self-aware."

The chimera froze mid-chew, gave him a flat look, then—deliberately—swiped its paw across the empty skewer with an audible *clack*.

Phainon’s grin widened. “Point taken.”

He shifted carefully forward, lowering his hand. “Let me just check you’re not bleeding out—”

The chimera tensed, then lashed out. Claws raked across his hand before he could pull away. Sharp sting, shallow cut. Golden blood welled bright against his skin.

Phainon hissed and flexed his fingers. “Ow—”

The chimera froze.

Its ears jerked back. For a moment it only stared at him, horrified. Its mouth opened like it meant to hiss again—but what came out was a small, wavering sound.

“…Awoo.”

A pitiful note, as if he hadn’t expected that also. It wasn’t a growl. Not quite a whimper either. Something between guilt and apology.

Phainon blinked. Then, against all sense, he laughed softly. “Well, didn’t expect that.”

The chimera lingered, restless, before creeping closer. Hesitation in every step. Then, gingerly, it clambered onto his lap. Its claws gripped fabric with surprising care. Its face brushed his hand—deliberately avoiding the wound—before darting out a quick, guilty lick.

Phainon’s expression softened. He rubbed gently along its back, fingers threading through matted fur.

“No need. It’s fine. Had worse from training dummies,” he murmured. “But you—” his gaze flicked to the limp, his tone firming—“you’re not fine. You need a check-up. Food I can replace. Injuries I can’t ignore.”

The chimera huffed, moving away from him as if unwilling to concede.

Phainon only chuckled, scratching lightly behind its ear.

He *should* take it to the Garden of Life. That had been the plan—was still the responsible plan.

But the little weight pressed warm against his chest.

Maybe keeping it, just a while, wouldn't hurt.

"…Suppose I can't just keep calling you 'chimera,'" he muttered. "Need a name, don't we?"

He thought, chewing the inside of his cheek. A few half-formed ideas floated past. None fit.

Then something tugged free from memory, sudden and bright.

Phainon's whole face lifted. He straightened, grin breaking wide.

"Well. You're more like a cat than a lion," he mused. "But… Snowy. After my childhood dog. Perfect."

The chimera blinked.

Then hissed, high and scandalized, as if to say *absolutely not. After your dog?*

Phainon laughed, delighted. "What, don't like it? Too bad." He scooped it up easily, ignoring its squirming outrage. "Snowy it is."

The chimera wriggled furiously, tail lashing, a picture of indignation—but not escaping.

Passersby paused at the sight: the Deliverer of Okhema striding through the streets with a chimera tucked into his arms like a temperamental cat.

Phainon only hummed cheerfully, brushing off the stares. "Nuh-uh. Check-up first. Then we'll argue names."

And with Snowy spitting protest against his chest, Phainon walked back toward the city.

And that—though he didn’t yet realize it—was how the whole mess began.

“They kicked him?!”

Hyacine’s voice carried across the courtyard infirmary, sharp enough that a few junior medics glanced over before hastily looking away.

Phainon inclined his head, the motion controlled but the tightness in his jaw betraying the temper under his words. “Hard to believe anyone would stoop that low. Shameful.”

Hyacine drew in a slow breath, her usual gentle features pinched. “I sincerely hope you’ll report it. People like that don’t deserve to slip by unnoticed.”

“There’s no need.” Phainon exhaled through his nose, tension easing only slightly as he leaned back. “Aglaea’s threads are always moving. If not now, then soon. She’ll see it handled.” His hand dropped, and he gestured toward the cot. “What matters is him. How is he?”

Snowy sat neat as porcelain against the cushions, fur smoothed from Hyacine’s careful fussing. His eyes tracked the room with quiet patience. At his flank, little Ica pressed close, a silent weight of comfort. The chimera hadn’t budged except for the faint twitch of his tail, betraying the irritation he refused to show otherwise.

Hyacine crouched to his level, fingers trailing over the faint remnants of fur that should’ve been bruised. “Remarkable, really. Every scrape I saw when he limped in has already closed over.” She glanced at her notes, almost disbelieving. “If I hadn’t seen the state he was in myself, I’d think this one never touched the ground.”

Phainon’s brows knit, though the relief in his eyes softened the line. “Good,” he said, then tilted his head, curiosity slipping in. “But… how?”

“That,” Hyacine admitted with a low hum, “I can’t explain. Maybe something buried in his genetics—but even then, this fast?” She shook her head faintly, a lock of hair falling loose before she tucked it behind her ear. “It’s almost miraculous.”

Snowy’s ears flicked back.

“I’d like to see him again if you’ll bring him by,” Hyacine went on gently. “Not for anything invasive—just to understand. He’s so well-behaved it’d be no trouble at all.”

“Mm.” Phainon’s agreement came easily, his gaze lingering on Snowy. His mouth twitched in a crooked smile. “Better behaved than Mydei, actually. At least Snowy doesn’t fight me every time I drag him to a bath.”

The chimera went still.

Slowly, he turned his head toward Phainon, fixing him with a glare sharp enough to cut marble.

Hyacine blinked at the intensity of it—and to her horror, a laugh almost bubbled out. She pressed it down, biting the inside of her cheek as Phainon carried on, oblivious.

“It’s true,” he added. “Snowy just sits there. Patient. Calm. Mydei—” his tone dipped into fond exasperation—“always has something to say about it.”

Hyacine chuckled. When she dared glance at Snowy again, his eyes were still fixed in a steady, offended burn on Phainon. Not beastly exactly. Just… utterly, humanly indignant.

Something inside her clicked.

“…Phainon,” she said lightly, as though testing a thread. “When was the last time you saw Lord Mydei?”

The question caught him off guard, but he answered without hesitation—anything involving Mydei always did. “Yesterday. We were supposed to

meet this morning, but—” he gave a small, rueful smile, “—the chance passed.”

Hyacine hummed, her gaze flicking once more to the chimera before her lips curved in sudden, soft amusement. “I see.”

Phainon tilted his head, brow furrowing. “See what?”

“Nothing,” she said, voice lilting, too sweet. “Only that he’s in excellent health, Lord Phainon. Very spirited.”

Snowy’s eyes narrowed into slits, his gaze redirected at her.

Hyacine, cheeks puffed slightly to hide her grin, reached for her pen. “Now, let’s just mark down his weight—”

A paw lashed out.

Smack. The pen clattered across the stone floor.

Phainon blinked, startled, then let out a laugh. “Well. That was sudden.”

Hyacine very nearly broke—her knuckles pressed against her lips, eyes bright with unshed laughter as she forced herself to recover. “Perhaps,” she managed, voice wobbling slightly, “he doesn’t care for paperwork.”

Snowy sat tall and still, his tail giving one decisive lash.

“Or,” Hyacine added, setting the pen aside with a little flourish, “he doesn’t care for me writing it.” Her smile softened again as she inclined her head toward him. “That’s alright. We’ll leave it for now.”

Snowy’s posture eased fractionally.

Phainon folded his arms, shaking his head. “Healthy, quick to recover, and opinionated. Guess he’ll keep me busy.”

Hyacine hid her grin behind her notes, though her eyes flicked to the chimera one last time, alight with mischief she didn’t voice.

Spirited, indeed.

Snowy dangled in the crook of Phainon’s arm like a particularly pampered pet, though his faintly narrowed eyes betrayed that he was only tolerating the indignity rather than enjoying it.

Phainon, for his part, seemed perfectly at ease, adjusting his hold with absentminded care.

“You’re getting used to this, aren’t you?” he said with a teasing lift of his brow, tilting Snowy so they were nearly eye-to-eye. “No claws, no growling… hm. Maybe you like it.”

Snowy’s ear twitched. He did not look away, which was perhaps as much of a retort as he’d allow.

Phainon chuckled under his breath, brushing a thumb along the line of Snowy’s jaw in a gesture so natural it might have been unconscious. “Cute thing.” The words slipped out softly, not quite cooing, but close enough that Snowy’s entire frame went taut.

Phainon didn’t notice—he only adjusted his grip, drawing Snowy a touch closer as he continued, “Now, listen. You’ll need to behave today. We’re going to meet someone important—a very special guest. Endure a little longer, and then I’ll take you home. Understood?”

Snowy blinked once, slow and unimpressed.

“Mm. I’ll take that as agreement.” Phainon smiled faintly, giving the chimera a light bounce in his arms as though coaxing a spark of spirit from him. “I’d meant to see her earlier, actually, but you—” his eyes softened briefly—“you needed me more.“

Snowy felt the warmth behind the words and had to avert his gaze, ears angling back in faint embarrassment.

Phainon went on musing aloud. “She won’t mind the delay. Still, best behavior, hm? You wouldn’t want to embarrass me.”

Snowy’s tail flicked sharply, brushing against his wrist like a lash.

Phainon only laughed. “That’s what I thought.”

They fell into a companionable silence. Phainon hummed tunelessly under his breath, his hand smoothing Snowy’s fur first the wrong way, then back again, clearly entertained by the faint bristle-and-relax he coaxed out each time.

Then, without warning, Phainon’s gaze lifted. The hum in his throat faded, replaced by a smile.

“…Speak of the devil.”

Snowy followed his gaze.

At the far end of the path, bent over a tray of herbs, a young woman carefully sorted stems and petals with gloved hands. She straightened slowly, catching sight of them. Her eyes met Phainon’s, and for the briefest moment, she seemed startled—then her expression smoothed out pleasantly.

“Lord Phainon,” Castorice greeted.

Phainon stopped before her, his posture relaxed. His answering smile was faint yet sincere. “Hello, Castorice.”

The chimera in his arms, however, did not look nearly so composed.

Castorice brushed an errant strand of hair behind her ear, setting aside the tray of herbs she had been sorting with practiced care. Her eyes lingered on him with an edge of polite concern. “You’re late. Did something happen?”

Phainon inclined his head in apology, voice smooth. “My apologies. Something… unexpected arose.” He shifted the bundle in his arms slightly, as if to punctuate the excuse.

Her gaze followed the motion, and only then did her brows rise faintly. “And who’s this?”

Phainon’s expression brightened. He glanced down, then—without hesitation—lifted the chimera up as though he were presenting a precious gift. “This is Snowy. My chimera.” His tone carried the pride of a craftsman introducing his finest work, or a lord unveiling a rare treasure.

Castorice studied Snowy in silence, her gaze not unkind but intent enough to make the creature bristle and avert his eyes. Courtesy tugged at him, however, and he risked a reluctant glance back—only to find her lips curve into a faint smile.

“Oh… I see, Lord Phainon. He suits you.”

Phainon gave a short, amused laugh. “Careful—he’ll take that as permission to demand offerings.”

Castorice’s mouth quirked, a small chuckle escaping her as she adjusted the cuff of her glove. “Then perhaps you deserve it.”

He arched a brow, his smile turning sly. “And here I thought you’d take my side.”

“I’ve been told I have good judgment,” she replied lightly.

Phainon shook his head. “It seems I’ve been outvoted.” With that, he steered their conversation back with practiced ease, his tone dipping into familiar cadence, and she matched it effortlessly.

What began as pleasantries stretched into a longer conversation. Castorice spoke of her day, mostly about a few photographs taken on her last journey with the Trailblazer—images of landscapes rendered stark and still, a fleeting moment of light across stone. Phainon, in turn, shared fragments of his own, mostly about some artifacts he’d appraised the day before.

Time slid by unnoticed under Kephale’s sun for a while. At last, Castorice glanced up at her telaslate, then back to the chimera in his arms. She

hesitated, studying him anew, before remarking, “Snowy should get a rinse.”

The chimera’s ears twitched at once, his head tilting toward her, wary.

She offered a small, matter-of-fact smile. “He’s quite clean, yes. But there’s still the look of the street about him. A proper bath would do him good.”

Phainon hummed thoughtfully, regarding the chimera as though the idea had only just dawned on him. “You may be right.”

Snowy turned his head slowly, fixing him with a flat, unimpressed stare.

Phainon’s grin spread. “Well then you heard her. Prepare yourself, little one—it’s bath time~.”

Snowy’s weakly lashed out, claws flexing against his sleeve. A single bead of sweat gathered at his temple—whether from dread or fury was difficult to tell.

Phainon only tightened his hold fractionally, as though anticipating resistance, and strode onward with an ease that made it clear the matter was already decided.

True to his word, Phainon had taken Snowy back with him. The walk home had worn the chimera down; by the time they crossed the threshold, his eyes were half-lidded, his small body shifting in the faint, drowsy movements of someone losing a battle against sleep. Phainon adjusted his hold without a thought, carrying him carefully.

The house was quiet—stone walls softened by shelves of books and jars and rugs that dulled the sound of his steps, the faint spice of herbs drifting from the windowsill.

In the main room, he slowed, considering letting the little one settle for the night. Snowy had gone nearly limp against his arm, his ears drooping

despite an attempt to stay alert. For a moment, Phainon nearly gave in, content to let him rest there.

But then—he changed his mind.

After a brief stop, he returned with a bundle tucked under one arm: brushes, oils, a bar of soap he'd once picked up at a market because it had been on a discount and oddly specific. Not human shampoo—he knew better than that. Chimera fur needed a gentler touch.

Which brought them, inevitably, to the bath.

The chamber was steady with steam, the wide tub already filled, water shifting as he tested it with his hand. He shrugged off his outer coat and set the bundle on a low bench before stepping in, the water rising around his calves.

Snowy had claimed the edge of the room, tail curled neatly, gaze fixed on the tub with a level, unblinking patience.

"Come on," Phainon said, coaxing as he stirred the water with his fingers. "It's only a bit of water now…"

He dipped his hand through the bathwater again, sending lazy ripples lapping against his ribs. The oils he'd mixed into it gave off the faint scent of cedar and thyme—soothing, grounding. Perfect, really. Everything was in order. Everything except the stubborn little beast parked just out of reach on the tile, glaring at him as though he'd suggested drowning instead of bathing.

"Really?" Phainon's tone was light but his patience was waning. "You're going to make me beg for this?"

Snowy blinked. Slowly. As though considering it.

The corner of Phainon's mouth twitched. Damn it, he was cute. Infuriating, but cute.

With a sigh through his nose, Phainon tilted his head. “Alright, fine. We’ll do it your way.”

Before the chimera could so much as twitch, Phainon leaned out of the tub and scooped him up against his chest in one clean, practiced motion. Snowy made a sharp little sound—half squeak, half yelp—startled more than distressed.

“Got you.” Phainon smirked, securing the compact weight against his torso.

The chimera wriggled once, kicking damply at his side like a sulky child, before being effortlessly pinned. Phainon stepped backward into the tub, chin resting casually atop the soft crown of fur. The water sloshed up around them both in a lazy wave.

“There we are,” he said, voice light. “Nothing dreadful about it.”

Snowy disagreed with his entire being.

Phainon laughed outright, his chest shaking where Snowy was pressed against him. “Oh, don’t look at me like that,” he teased, smoothing a broad hand down the damp fur of Snowy’s back. “You’d think I’d tossed you into the River of Souls.”

Snowy choked. Audibly.

Phainon blinked, pausing, then shrugged. “Well, not literally.” He chuckled at his own joke, and Snowy clawed at his sleeve with dull little talons that said, very clearly, *take that back.*

“Mmhm.” Phainon hummed as if humoring him. His hand left Snowy’s back just long enough to reach for the soap on the wooden bench. Without thinking, he adjusted his grip—pressing the small body more firmly against his collarbone. His chin lowered again to anchor him there.

And in that casual, absent gesture, he effectively plastered the chimera’s face to his bare chest.

The effect was immediate.

Snowy went rigid.

Phainon frowned faintly, glancing down. From this angle, all he could see were ears flattened tight against damp fur. “What’s this? Giving up already?” His voice was wry, though something about the abrupt stillness pricked uneasily at him.

Nothing. Not even a twitch.

“Strange,” Phainon murmured, shifting his hold experimentally.

Snowy stayed locked for several heartbeats more—until, gradually, that stiffness began to unravel. Slowly. Painfully slowly. The rigid body softened by degrees until Phainon felt it melt forward into him. A reluctant collapse, fur brushing into the hollow of his collarbone, cheek pressing tentatively against warm skin.

Phainon stilled, caught off guard, then let out a low chuckle. “Ah. There now, that’s better.” His palm stroked along Snowy’s back, tone unbothered. “See? Not so terrible after all.”

Snowy offered no response beyond the weight of his body, which leaned and leaned and leaned—ears half-drooped now, claws slipped loose from Phainon’s sleeve. He was pliant, boneless suddenly.

Phainon, oblivious to anything peculiar in it, allowed it. For a solid minute or more, he stood there in the warm water with the little creature plastered against his chest, smiling faintly to himself at how quickly the fight had drained out of him. The sound of dripping water and the occasional splash filled the silence. It was…peaceful. Cozy, even.

Finally, remembering his task, Phainon reached for the soap again. “Alright then,” he murmured, easing Snowy back just enough to look down at him. “Now we’re going to—”

He froze.

Snowy’s pupils were blown wide, nearly swallowing the pale white of his irises. His gaze was unfocused, dazed, his body still limp against Phainon’s arm.

Phainon’s heart lurched. “*Snowy!* Are you—are you alright!?” He clutched him closer on instinct, panic sparking sharp and immediate. The water wasn’t that hot, was it? Had he—gods, had he pressed too hard?

“Snowy?” His voice pitched tight with alarm.

The chimera twitched then, head giving a small shake as though rousing from a trance. His pupils remained dilated, but his eyes flicked up with a shred of awareness now, tracking Phainon’s face.

Phainon exhaled, relief loosening his chest though his brow stayed furrowed. “You…scared me.”

For a moment, he hesitated, uncertain what to do. Then Snowy’s muzzle nudged gently at his arm. A soft press—wordless reassurance.

Phainon blinked, startled, before clearing his throat. “…Right. Soap.”

Still concerned, but unwilling to break the fragile calm, he set about lathering the bar in one hand. His gaze flicked down every so often, watchful, as though half-expecting the chimera to keel over.

“We’ll go slow,” he said, more to himself than to Snowy, though his gaze kept darting down, as if to reassure them both.

Just in case.

Phainon got the soap working with a bit more vigor than necessary, rubbing the bar between his palms until it blossomed into a froth of bubbles. Within moments, his hands were covered in an alarming amount of white foam, suds slipping down his wrists. He glanced down at Snowy, who had been watching the process quietly.

“See? Nothing to worry about,” Phainon murmured cheerfully.

Snowy’s expression soured further.

Before Phainon could make sense of it, the chimera wriggled sharply in his hold. Startled, Phainon instinctively pulled him closer to steady him—too fast. The movement backfired spectacularly, and in the scramble, Snowy ended up shoved beard-deep into the soapy froth.

“Ah—!” Phainon laughed, tugging him upright again with a careful hand cupped under his small body. The chimera’s face was plastered in suds, tufts of wet fur sticking every which way. His glare was real enough to be almost human.

“Shh, shh—it’s fine. You look majestic,” Phainon teased, half-cooing as he brushed foam from the little one’s ears. “Like some ancient lion carved into a temple wall. Don’t fight it.”

Snowy gave a quiet huff through his nose, unimpressed, but he stilled in Phainon’s hands.

The silence stretched for a moment, broken only by the slosh of water as Phainon began scrubbing gently along Snowy’s back. It felt oddly strange to him, being quiet with someone—even a chimera. So, almost without thinking, he started to talk.

“You really are stubborn,” he mused aloud, working suds carefully into Snowy’s fur. “You dig in your heels about the strangest things. Reminds me of Mydei sometimes. He’s the same way—won’t budge unless it’s on his own terms. Drives me half mad, but I can’t help but…” He trailed for half a second, shook his head, then chuckled faintly. “Ah, never mind. Point is, you’ve got the same streak. Hard to handle, but kind of endearing.”

Snowy blinked slowly, suds sliding down his snout.

Phainon dipped his hand back into the water, rinsing the soap off with a sweep. His mind wandered, words spilling before he could stop them. “You know, the really maddening thing is… you wouldn’t expect it just looking at him. Mydei doesn’t even try to stand out. But then—” Phainon’s voice

brightened, like he'd stumbled on the perfect way to explain it, "then you see his *body*."

Snowy choked.

Phainon carried on. "No, I mean it—his body is absurd. Absolutely unfair. Broad shoulders, arms that could snap a tree in half, legs built like he was carved for war. And it's not just for show—gods, the way he moves. Every strike, every sparring session—he throws himself into it like it's nothing. He endures things that should break him and still comes out standing. Stronger every time. It's like the world itself bends around him instead of the other way around."

He laughed quietly, fingertips absently brushing suds down Snowy's side. "And don't even get me started on his muscles. Every one of them is just—gods, they shouldn't look that good, but they do. Like someone etched them into him on purpose. It's infuriating. He's immortal and somehow he still looks like a legend ripped out an epic."

The words softened as they tumbled out, his smile slipping into something quieter. "Every time I think I've reached the limit of what his body can take, he proves me wrong again. It's beautiful, really."

Only then did he pause. He blinked down at the chimera in his hands.

Snowy had gone very still again.

Phainon's heart lurched. "Oh no, don't do that again." He lifted him a little higher, trying to see his eyes. "Breathe, little guy." His tone was coaxing, but edged with genuine worry.

He swore he felt the faintest sigh against his chest, the smallest motion of life, and only then did his shoulders relax by a fraction.

"Better," he murmured, pressing him close again. "Don't keep scaring me like that."

Still, even as he reached for more water to rinse the soap away, his gaze flickered down, troubled. He'd ask Hyacine tomorrow—just to be safe.

Phainon padded out of the steamy bathroom with Snowy in tow, towel slung low at his hips, water still trailing in lazy rivulets down his chest. The bath had gone better than expected—after that frozen spell, the chimera hadn't fought nearly as hard. Maybe Snowy had resigned himself, or maybe the soap had won the war. Either way, he was clean now, and smelled a lot less like damp iron.

Triumph dimmed, however, when Phainon realized mid-step that he hadn't grabbed him a towel. He stared at the dripping bundle in his arms. "…Oh. Right. You need one of those too."

Snowy's only answer was an eye twitch.

Phainon glanced around, shrugged, and pulled his coat off the bench. The heavy white fabric was far too big, swallowing Snowy whole until he resembled some sulking winter burrito—ears crooked, tail poking out at one end, tiny face peeking miserably from the collar.

Phainon's grin cracked wide. "You look adorable."

Snowy immediately buried his face deeper, as if he could sink into the coat and erase existence altogether.

"Oh, don't do that, I mean it," Phainon crooned, voice dropping into something dangerously close to baby-talk. "Look at you. Perfect little bundle. Gods, you're going to kill me with that face." He fussed at the coat folds, trying not to hug him too tight, though his hands twitched with the urge. What had the Trailblazer called it? *Cuteness aggression?* Yes, that. That was it exactly.

Snowy groaned muffled protest into the fabric.

"Alright, alright," Phainon relented as he carried him into the bedroom.

He settled Snowy onto the bed and finally traded the makeshift burrito-wrap for a proper weighted blanket. That seemed to do the trick; once it settled heavy across his frame, the chimera eased minutely, shoulders loosening. Phainon hummed his approval as he rummaged for his own clothes.

Snowy for his part, became very invested in the wall during the process. Not the man changing right there, definitely not the flex and pull of muscle across his torso as he tugged on his shorts, nope. The wall was fascinating. A marvel of architecture. Perfectly rectangular.

Phainon flopped back onto the mattress, half-dressed and wholly comfortable, sprawling like someone who had very much earned the right. Snowy ended up half-tucked against his chest in the mess of blanket and limbs, like a misplaced pillow Phainon refused to let go of.

“Tomorrow morning…” Phainon’s voice came softer now, slurred faintly with sleep but still reassuring, “I’ll definitely find Mydei. You two should meet.” His arm curled automatically, drawing Snowy more firmly into the crook of it. “And Cyrene too—you’d like her.”

The chimera paused faintly.

Phainon’s tone shifted with a thread of fondness, the kind drawn up from memory. “Back in Aedes Elysiae, when the farm work was done, Cyrene and I would make my Snowy chase us for fun. Gods, he’d bound across the fields all teeth and silly, and we thought it was the best game in the world.” A chuckle escaped him, rich but soft with nostalgia. “We were stupid kids. But it was fun.”

His smile lingered only a moment before fading into a sigh. “…Never mind.”

Thinking about it now, he misses Snowy.

He brushed a stray tuft of fur flat, tugged the blanket a little higher over Snowy’s shoulders, and murmured, “Get some rest. You need it.”

Snowy stayed still, eyes on him, unblinking.

“See you tomorrow,” Phainon mumbled. His voice grew faint as his head tilted into the pillow, sleep catching up to him fast. Today was a tiring day, after all.

For a long moment the only sound was the rhythm of his breathing. Snowy’s gaze didn’t move. Then, slowly—so slowly it was almost cautious—he leaned into the warmth, nuzzling into Phainon’s neck. Just enough to settle. Just enough to take comfort.

The arm around him never stirred, but it held him steady as he let his eyes close at last.

Contrary to belief, Phainon did not find Mydei the next day.

Or the day after that.

Or the day *after* that.

For three whole days, his sanity ticked like a clock wound too tight. He scoured Okhema up and down, retraced his steps until his boots threatened to carve grooves into the cobblestones, even debated storming Kremnos personally—until Krateros himself finally snapped that no, Mydeimos was not there.

So. Three days. And Phainon was starting to twitch.

He was man enough to admit it: he had Mydei withdrawal symptoms. They were ugly. His chest buzzed with restless energy, his jaw locked at night, and every shadow looked like it *might* have been him, until it wasn’t. He didn’t like it.

On the bright side, his relationship with Snowy had… improved. Considerably.

Sure, there had been incidents. Like the time Phainon thought teaching him to roll over was a good idea. (Spoiler: it was not.) Or the salad bowl debacle

—apparently chimera (Or at least Snowy) did not, in fact, eat lettuce and tomatoes. Who knew.

But now? Now the little beast perched on his shoulder like a monarch, tail curled like a pennant. Phainon had even caught himself peeling pomegranate seeds one by one to hand-feed the rascal, who snapped them up like a spoiled noble before settling back into his throne spot as if this were the natural order of the universe.

And Phainon… well. He didn't mind.

On today's walk, the women of the city had noticed. They leaned from windows or paused with baskets in hand, cooing over his "new companion" and—much to his embarrassment—teasing him about finally finding himself a proper little pet. He tried to laugh it off, but when Snowy was offered free figs, honey cakes, and—at one stall—a whole lamb skewer, Phainon swore the chimera's smug smirk grew three sizes.

But all that was background noise. Because now, finally, he had reached his destination.

Marmoreal Palace.

The baths gleamed like carved pearl in the morning light, steam already curling, perfumed with oils and herbs. The place was vast, vaulted, alive with the echo of footsteps and trickling water. Phainon hummed under his breath, rolling his shoulders back as he crossed the threshold.

"Alright," he muttered, patting Snowy once as if he were a squire before battle. "Get ready."

Snowy yawned and flicked his tail in a way that suggested he was ready for nothing.

Phainon didn't hesitate. His stride carried him through the steamy corridors with a confidence bordering on reckless. He knew the turns; he knew where she'd be. And sure enough—

There.

Golden hair caught the light ahead, damp at the ends, the faint sheen of steam still clinging to skin. Robes belted neatly at her waist, she had just left the baths.

Phainon’s grin broke wide. “Aglaea!”

Her head turned at once, sharp and fluid, as though she’d already been aware of him approaching. Her eyes flicked over him—the weariness clinging to his shoulders, the tired lines bracketing his smile, and, most of all, the small chimera perched on him like a gaudy accessory.

Her lips curved, just slightly. “Phainon.”

Snowy puffed his chest out proudly, then ruined it by looking away, oddly bashful.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck, his smile tilting crooked.

Phainon barely let Aglaea’s name leave his lips before the words followed.

“Aglaea, you wouldn’t happen to know where my companion is, would you?”

His tone wasn’t rude—never to her—but the sharp edge of impatience bled through despite his best effort to hide it.

Aglaea blinked once, slowly.

“Straight to business, then?” she murmured.

Before Phainon could answer, Snowy betrayed him.

The chimera, who for near a week claimed Phainon’s shoulder as his sovereign throne, suddenly flicked his tail and leapt. Phainon startled, lunging half-forward, horrified he was about to splatter himself across the marble. Instead, Snowy landed neatly, shook himself once like a prince

dusting his cloak, and trotted toward Aglaea as though called by invisible fanfare.

Phainon's jaw almost unhinged.

Nearly a week of shared meals, loyalty, even hand-picked pomegranate seeds—and Snowy did not give a shit. Damn.

Aglaea did not so much as blink at the approach. She bent smoothly, gathering Snowy into her arms as though this was his rightful place all along. He let her hold him with a rumble—civil, restrained, but unmistakably polite. Dignified, too: his head tilted as though recognizing her rank.

Phainon could only stare.

"…Really?" he muttered under his breath.

Aglaea smoothed her hand over the chimera's fur with practiced ease, her expression unreadable save for the tiniest hum.

"So," she said, stroking behind Snowy's ear, "that's what this is about."

Phainon opened his mouth, then shut it again. His hand flexed at his side. He wasn't going to let silence win—but he could wait her out.

"Not to worry."

Phainon's brow twitched. He waited.

"Mydeimos is away," she continued. "A mission. Nothing dangerous. He will return—within a week, two at most."

The tension that had been gnawing at Phainon's ribs eased—but not enough. He exhaled hard, eyes narrowing. "…Then why wasn't I told? Why didn't anyone know he'd gone?"

"Because," she murmured, almost to herself, "a certain cunning thief is to blame."

Her voice sharpened a breath later. “But the matter is contained. There’s nothing more to worry over, it’s only a matter of time.”

Phainon ground his jaw, torn between relief and annoyance. In the end, he let out a sigh.

“…Fine. I’ll trust that.”

“Good,” she said simply.

The pause that followed was thick with the soft trickle of water in the baths, the echo of sandals on marble, the perfume of oils warming the air. Phainon rolled his shoulders, forcing the knot between them to ease. His gaze flicked once more to Snowy, lounging in Aglaea’s arms like a usurper on his stolen throne.

He crooked two fingers. “Come on, Snowy. Time to go.”

Snowy blinked. Then—traitor that he was—he burrowed closer against Aglaea’s side, eyelids sinking in content.

Phainon’s face twitched. “…Unbelievable.”

Aglaea’s hand moved with grace down the chimera’s back. Her voice dropped low as she whispered to him.

“Endure a little longer.”

Snowy stilled, then, after a beat, wriggled free and padded back to Phainon’s shoulder. He perched neatly, tail curling around Phainon’s neck, nonchalant as though nothing had happened.

Phainon sighed at him, half-offended. “Oh, *now* you remember who feeds you. Great timing.” Still, the small smile tugging his lips betrayed more relief than irritation.

Aglaea inclined her head in a dismissal, her gaze lingering on the chimera a heartbeat longer before shifting back to him.

Phainon adjusted his grip, gave her one last look, and turned toward the doors. His footsteps echoed into the steam, lighter for the answers—but still restless.

Phainon had been walking for what felt like hours—not because he had anywhere to be, but because if he stood still too long his own thoughts started pacing. Snowy had trotted faithfully along for most of it, his paws clicking soft against the ground. The chimera had clearly decided that the great view from Phainon's shoulder wasn't worth the ride tonight.

Phainon didn't complain. Not until he actually *looked* down.

"…Kephale above," he muttered, halting. "What happened to you? You're a tangle."

Snowy sat back on his haunches, perfectly serene. His golden eyes gave him the kind of lofty look priests had when they pretended not to notice your sins. *Yes, I am a mess. And what of it?*

Phainon dragged a hand over his face, then huffed out a laugh. "Unbelievable."

With a flourish, he reached into the ridiculously oversized bag slung over his shoulder and hauled it forward. The thing hit the ground with a *thunk*, rattling with enough supplies to outfit a whole menagerie.

"Lucky for you…" He grinned, fishing around before brandishing a brush like a prize. "I told you this'd come in handy!"

Snowy blinked once. Slow. Then shut his eyes with all the gravity of a condemned man. Peace had been chosen.

Phainon chuckled, smug. "Smart choice. Resistance is futile."

There was a bench nearby beneath the glow of a lantern. He plopped onto it, then tugged Snowy into his lap. The chimera gave one token squirm before sprawling boneless.

“That’s better,” Phainon muttered. The brush moved through fur with steady strokes—firm, but careful, never catching hard. His hand followed after, smoothing the coat down like he was trying to press calm into the chimera by touch alone.

Snowy stilled, then settled like stone.

“Mm.” Phainon’s mouth quirked. “Don’t think I forgot about earlier. Nearly left me high and dry, ran right up to Aglaea like we hadn’t been through a dozen things together. What was that, huh?”

Snowy twitched an ear, unbothered.

“Traitor,” Phainon grumbled, but the word lacked teeth. His strokes stayed maddeningly gentle, untangling snarls with patience he rarely showed.

Silence stretched, broken only by the rasp of bristles. Phainon leaned back against the bench, shoulders sinking. The restless edge drained from him stroke by stroke, until his jaw went slack and he let out a yawn that seemed to scrape out the bottom of his lungs.

“…I miss Mydei already,” he muttered, voice low, almost surprised at itself.

Snowy’s head jerked an inch, eyes snapping open.

The words just… hung there. He rarely admitted to things like that. Certainly not out loud. But then he glanced down at Snowy’s placid face, fur in his lap, and the thought settled again. This was just a chimera. Who was it going to tell?

“It’s too damn quiet without him,” Phainon went on, softer now. “I keep waiting for him to mouth off. Call me a HKS. Anything.” He huffed a small laugh. “Feels wrong when it’s not there.”

Snowy’s tail flicked once, betraying tension.

“I miss sparring, too,” Phainon continued, voice dipping even lower. “Nobody fights like him. Nobody *looks* at me like he does when he’s

fighting. Makes me feel like… like he's the only one really seeing me. Weird to say, right?"

He fell quiet, breath rough for a beat, before words spilled again.

"And the stupid errands. He made even those good. The challenges. Training's not the same without him. And—" his mouth curved in a helpless smile, "—the baths. Gods, the baths. That immortal body is absolu —"

The brush jerked sideways as Snowy smacked at it with a paw.

Phainon choked on a laugh. "Pfft—what? Don't like the truth being spoken?"

Snowy growled low, but Phainon's grip on the brush was unyielding.

"Alright, alright." His grin sharpened, amusement glinting in his eyes. "You've got my undivided attention now. Just you, Snowy. Enjoying it~?"

The drawl in his voice dipped into something dangerously lazy, a shade of teasing that would've set any sane person blushing scarlet if they'd been in Snowy's place—and human.

Snowy buried his face in Phainon's chest, body tensing, tail giving away a tremor.

Phainon only laughed again, softer this time, and kept brushing, his hand lingering like he was unwilling to stop.

The lantern above flickered gold against the night air, bells chimed faintly in the distance. And there he sat: a man with a chimera curled in his lap, brushing him like a doll, whispering truths he'd never admit to another soul.

And if he felt lighter after letting it spill, well—Snowy wasn't about to tell.

The sun burned gold across the practice yard, its light catching on every moted grain of dust still hanging in the air. The soldiers around him were

doubled over, sweat dripping down their temples, still catching their breath. Yet despite the ragged gasps, more than one of them was smiling.

“Thank you, sir—it was an honor sparring with you!” one managed between heaves, sweat plastering his hair to his brow.

Phainon laughed, clapping the young man on the shoulder in a way that nearly bowled him over again. “Nonsense, you held your ground well. Just—wider stance next time. Plant your weight better.”

A ripple of thanks followed. Others offered awkward bows, quick grins, even muttered praise among themselves. It was a chorus Phainon had grown used to hearing, but it never failed to make his chest warm. “Good work today. Now—” he waved a hand toward the bottles cooling in the shade, “before I’m accused of murder, go drink before one of you collapses on me.”

That earned laughter before they trickled off in pairs and groups, leaning on each other and recounting little moments of their bouts like trophies.

When the yard finally quieted, Phainon exhaled, stretching his arms high until his joints popped. His muscles were pleasantly heavy with exertion, but still restless. They were good fighters—better than most—but they weren’t Mydei.

No one carried that same edge, that razor-sharp weight behind every strike that left Phainon grinning like a madman even as bruises bloomed. Without that, this was all… training. Important, fulfilling, sure. But not the fight. Not the dance.

With a sigh, he leaned his back against a shaded pillar, hair damp against the stone. Still, it wasn’t wasted effort. Helping them grow, sharpening their instincts—that mattered. Even if his own edge itched for better company.

By the time he rinsed off and headed home, the ache in his limbs had dulled into something warm, sluggish. The kind of fatigue that only wanted to be poured out across a mattress. Which he did—shirtless, damp-haired, sprawled wide across the bed as the cool air slid over his skin.

“Mmm,” he groaned, tilting his head toward movement at the edge of the bed. Snowy was prowling there, nose twitching suspiciously as if inspecting him.

Phainon huffed a chuckle and patted his abs like one might pat a chair. “C’mere, Snowy. Best seat in the house.”

The chimera hesitated, ears flicking, then hopped up with careful grace. Phainon guided him higher, settling the small body atop his stomach like it weighed nothing.

“There we are,” Phainon murmured, scratching slowly along Snowy’s spine. His nails traced lazy lines down fur and muscle, kneading at the shoulders before sliding lower again. Warm. Gods, warmer than expected. He let his palm rest there, feeling the steady lift and fall of breath beneath. “Like a little furnace. You’d put fire pits out of business come winter.”

Snowy harrumphed, curling tighter.

Phainon smiled faintly, not thinking much of it. His strokes grew slow, absentminded. His thoughts wandered aloud before he realized he was speaking.

“Sparring today was decent. Some solid fighters in the bunch. A few even made me think.” He tapped his stomach idly with his free hand.

Snowy’s chin nudged against his ribs.

“But it’s more teaching than sparring, really. I swear if I don’t get another mission soon I’ll start to rot.” He sighed. “Good exercise, sure. But no one’s keeping pace. Not like…” His words faded into a hum. Not like Mydei.

Phainon brightened suddenly, grin tugging at his mouth. “Oh—actually, one of them stood out today. Alexander, I think? Still green, lot to polish, but—you should’ve seen it. He parried me clean.” His hand, still resting along Snowy’s back, tapped once with the memory. “Most hesitate, fumble, but he caught the timing perfectly. Quick reflexes.”

He chuckled, voice warming with enthusiasm. “If he’d pressed harder, maybe he could’ve taken me off balance. Nearly did, the little prodigy. You don’t see that often—not here, not at his stage.”

Snowy shifted against him, slow and deliberate, curling tighter against Phainon’s side.

Unaware, Phainon continued, voice quickening like he was running downhill. “Don’t get me wrong, he’s nowhere near ready. But you can tell, can’t you? That spark. The bones of something sharp if he keeps at it. You give a fighter like that time, guidance, and—hah, I’d like to see where he ends up.”

His nails idly scratched the chimera’s side, trying to coax him into relaxing again. “Of course, not like he’s as cute as you. Don’t worry. Just—rare to see someone catch my eye like that. Gives me hope, you know?”

The chimera’s head tilted up, eyes fixed on him, unreadable.

Phainon chuckled, mistaking it for some kind of reproach. He scratched under the jaw, gentle. “Don’t look at me like that. It’s just excitement. No one’s replacing you, Snowy. You’re still my best seat, my best listener. Alexander could never compete with that.”

Snowy’s tail flicked once, sharp, before curling close again.

“Thought so.” Phainon yawned and leaned back into the pillows. His hand kept its rhythm—slow strokes down fur—as Snowy’s silence pressed closer around them.

Maybe tomorrow would be better.

Tomorrow, in fact, did not get better.

Why exactly?

Well, Snowy was minding his business. As he often did. A very important business, at that—the business of devouring a freshly filled bowl of hand-squeezed pomegranate juice, ruby red staining his mouth until he looked like a tiny predator fresh from a kill. He lowered his head again, tongue lapping as though nothing in the world mattered more.

He was halfway through the massacre when the door creaked open, and in breezed Phainon.

Snowy didn't look up. He'd learned better.

"Snowy, you would not believe the day I've had," Phainon declared, striding in like a hero returning from war. He collapsed into the nearest chair with a thud, leaned forward on his knees, and launched into his story before Snowy even twitched an ear.

"You know Theodoros, right? From the antique shop? Anyway, he's drowning. Half the city decided to dump their 'family treasures' on him overnight. Poor man looked like he was about to burst into tears when I walked in. Honestly, I thought he was going to kiss me when I offered to help. Which, uh, would've been… a lot."

Snowy slurped his juice. Loudly.

"And gods, the *stuff* people brought in. A vase that was definitely just a goat's water bowl, a pile of coins that looked like they'd come out of a children's game set, and—oh, oh—you're going to love this. Someone tried to sell a temple plate. Except it was mass-made last year. I mean, the audacity! I almost applauded."

Snowy blinked. Slowly.

"But," Phainon said, jabbing a finger skyward as though Snowy had raised an argument, "there were some gems too. A lacquer box from Janusopolis, still shiny after all these years. A carved pendant with jade inlay—so detailed I swear you'd need a magnifying glass not to lose yourself in it. And then this fragment of a marble statue, smooth as river stone, clearly part of an offering piece. Gorgeous work. I swear, Mydei would've—"

He paused. A light flickered on behind his eyes. Then, as casually as someone remembering they'd left the stove on, he said:

"Oh yeah. I think I'm in love with Mydei."

Snowy went face-first into the bowl.

Juice geysered. Seeds splattered across the table. It looked like a crime scene.

Phainon shot upright. "*Snowy?!*"

Snowy did not move. He lay there, chin planted in the blood-red mess, perfectly still, as though choosing suffocation over the conversation.

Phainon leaned closer, panicked. "…Are you choking? Or did you just—what is this—did you just *decide* to drown in fruit?"

The only answer was a long, muffled exhale, somewhere between a groan and a death rattle.

Phainon sat back, scratching at the back of his neck. "…Huh. Guess you're sick of pomegranates."

Snowy raised his head slowly. Pulp and juice clung to his face like war paint. He stared at Phainon with the kind of silence that could break a man's will.

This was going to be a long day.

"Right, we'll clean you up later," Phainon said, eyeing the dripping mess of juice still clinging to Snowy's chin. He sat back down, folding his arms with a determined little nod. "But first—about my confess—"

Snowy toppled sideways.

No warning, no buildup. Just a tiny, exaggerated flop, complete with a squeaky little *huff* as he sprawled across the table like a martyr struck down mid-battle.

Phainon froze. Then blinked once. “…Are you kidding me.”

Snowy did not move. He was perfectly still, legs askew, tail limp, eyes squeezed dramatically shut like a cheap stage actor.

“Snowy,” Phainon whined, running both hands down his face. “Don’t do this to me right now.”

Snowy gave the faintest twitch, the kind you’d expect from someone who wanted to make sure you noticed they were dying.

“Ughhh.” Phainon leaned back with an exasperated groan, tilting his head skyward like he was asking the gods why they hated him. “Usually this would be the part where I panic and rush you to a healer. But nooo, I know you better than that now. I know when you’re actually hurt.” He dragged his gaze back down to the chimera sprawled in fake death throes. “…And this is not it.”

Snowy stuck out his tongue. Just slightly.

“Oh come on!” Phainon buried his face in his hands. “Snowyyy, you can’t just fake-faint every time I try to talk about this. I need to talk to someone about it! Do you know how insane I feel, keeping this bottled up?”

Snowy’s only reply was to twitch again, somehow managing to look even *deader*.

“…Unbelievable.” Phainon slapped his knees and stood. “Fine. Lie there. Pretend you’re dead. I’ll just talk to you anyway.” He pointed accusingly at the chimera’s limp form. “You can’t stop me.”

Snowy cracked one eye open, gave him the slowest, most withering look imaginable, then shut it again with the finality of a coffin lid.

A very long day indeed.

“Well… for one,” Phainon began, voice pitched low, “Mydei has not even been gone a week. A *week*, Snowy. And yet I feel as though my very chest

has been hollowed out, as though something essential, vital, has been ripped clean from me."

Snowy's ear flicked.

Phainon raked both hands through his hair and gave a laugh that wasn't really a laugh at all. "Every sparring match—do you understand what that means to me? Every single bout with him is the highlight of my week. Sometimes of the *month*. I swear I only breathe properly when he's trying to stab me!"

Snowy's snapped straight up, his head whipping toward him like *what the actual fuck did you just say.*

"Not literally, obviously!" Phainon flailed a hand, nearly smacking his own forehead. "He's careful. Gentle, even, in his way. He'd never willingly cause me harm, and that—oh, Titans, that is what destroys me. To fight someone who could gut me in an instant, who *should* gut me in an instant, but who instead chooses restraint—" He staggered forward, clutching the back of a chair like he might faint. "Do you know what that does to me? It's maddening. Maddening in the best way."

Snowy blinked very slowly, as if he were watching a nobleman publicly collapse at a market square and had no idea whether to fetch help or just keep walking.

"And the worst part?" Phainon pressed on, wild-eyed. "The *worst part* is that I even enjoy losing to him." He leaned down sharply, as though Snowy were his jury. "Do you hear me? Losing! Who in their sane mind enjoys losing?"

Snowy didn't respond.

But Phainon only grew more frantic. He slapped both hands to his knees, leaned closer, and hissed, "I do. *I do.* I can't stop thinking about him. Everything—training, meals, even sleep—it all feels brighter, better, fuller when he's near."

Snowy's side-eye had become worse.

"And it isn't merely liking," Phainon breathed, his chest tight, his voice shaking. "No. Titans, the man could stab me and I would thank him for the honor—"

THWACK.

Snowy's tail cracked the floor like a whip.

Phainon jumped a foot, then collapsed back into his chair with a groan, dragging his hands down his face. "Don't—don't look at me like that, I *know* how it sounds! Embarrassing. Ridiculous." He rocked forward, hair falling into his eyes, staring at Snowy with the desperation of a man being dragged under the tide. "But it's true."

He shot back to his feet, pacing now like a priest delivering a sermon at the end of days. "I am not even exaggerating. If he told me to leap into a volcano, I would ask whether he preferred me swan-diving or cannonballing."

Snowy choked—actually *choked*—a strangled, half-growl half-wheeze that sounded alarmingly like a death rattle trying to claw its way out. His fur puffed. His tail lashed.

"And it's the *little things*!" Phainon rounded on him, pointing an accusatory finger like Snowy had demanded proof. "It's not even the obvious—his skill, his presence, his damned eyes—it's the details. I like talking with him because he never puts up with my nonsense, yet still lets me speak. He listens. Do you understand what that means? To actually be *listened to*?"

Snowy was shrinking backward by inches, claws leaving faint furrows in the wood.

"And sitting next to him—" Phainon's hand flew to his chest, his voice lowering, breaking now into something raw. "Gods, sitting next to him. I cannot explain it. He just smells… good. And I find myself memorizing it like a starving man memorizes bread. It's—*addictive*. It's destroying me."

He turned to Snowy.

“Snowy, what do I do?” Phainon cried, gripping his shirt as though his heart might tear itself out. “He’s only been gone for a week, and look at me! I am unraveling. I have never—never—felt like this. Not for anyone. Not once in my cursed, blasted life.” His eyes grew glassy, his whole body pitched forward with helpless sincerity. “Tell me I am not mad.”

Snowy’s fur had gone scarlet at this point. Quite literally. He gave the smallest shuffle backward, as though two more inches of distance might spare him from further cardiac collapse, his claws clicking against the floor with his ears red.

But Phainon did not notice. He collapsed into his chair, bent double, burying his face in his hands. His voice came muffled, broken, raw: “Gods help me, Snowy. I am in love with him.”

A long silence stretched.

Then, slowly, Snowy lifted a paw and smacked it straight against his own forehead like a human man overwhelmed by the idiocy of another. His chest heaved—too fast, too uneven—like someone struggling to breathe.

Phainon peered up through his fingers, frowning. “…Are you all right?”

Snowy wheezed.

Phainon was still half-adrift when his hands moved on instinct and scooped Snowy clean off the ground. The chimera gave a startled, undignified *mrrp!* but was immediately tucked against his chest like a favored pillow.

“Funny thing,” Phainon murmured, rubbing absently at Snowy’s ears as though he were smoothing out the wrinkles in his own mind. “I’d love to say I realized this all by myself—some grand epiphany, heavens parting, choir singing, you know the bit.” He made a vague gesture. “But no. Of course not.”

He groaned, letting his head loll back against the wall, still hugging Snowy tighter.

“It had to be Stelle.” His voice was dark. “She’d just wrapped up her trip to Ampherous, and I thought I’d be polite. Civilized Go say goodbye before she hopped on the Express again.”

Snowy twitched faintly in his hold.

“It was normal,” Phainon continued, scowling into the middle distance. “Trip highlights, safe travels, that kind of thing. And then somehow—*somehow*—the conversation turned to Mydei.”

“And you know me,” Phainon went on with a helpless shrug. “Five minutes without mentioning him? Impossible. I swear it slips out of my mouth like a bad habit. And Stelle…” He grimaced. “She smelled blood in the water.”

Phainon scrubbed his face with one hand. “She said I wasn’t just in love, I was… what were her words—‘terminally down bad,’ like it was eating my bones. Said I look at him like he’s some kind of rare collectible.” His voice cracked with offense. “A limited-edition gacha pull. Whatever the hell that means.”

He sighed.

“And if that wasn’t humiliating enough,” Phainon pressed on, tightening his hold as if trying to crush the memory into Snowy’s fur, “she threatened me. Told me if I didn’t confess soon, *she’d do it for me*. And she’d make it worse. Can you imagine? Stelle, of all people, airing out my feelings?”

He buried his face into Snowy’s fluff with another heavy sigh, muffling his next words. “And then she asked if I’d started a shrine.”

“I told her no, obviously.” Phainon’s tone was grave. “But now I keep wondering if maybe it would help. Incense. Candles. A framed picture, tastefully lit. It’s not insane.”

Snowy made a thin, desperate rasping sound.

“Don’t give me that look,” Phainon muttered, still nestled in his fur. “You’re the only one who understands. At least you’re on my side.”

Snowy could only stare at him—stunned, wide-eyed, caught between horror and the kind of wild, elated panic that made his whole body feel like it was burning alive.

Phainon mistook the silence for agreement, stroking a paw with solemn gratitude. “Exactly. I knew you’d get it.”

By the time the pot of stew was finally bubbling, the kitchen smelled warm and rich, herbs and root vegetables mingling with the broth in a way that made Phainon feel very proud of himself. He’d even gone so far as to dice everything neatly, just the way his mother once taught him—because why shouldn’t a chimera get a proper meal?

“See, Snowy?” he said brightly, setting the steaming bowl down in front of the creature perched on the counter. “Balanced. Nutritious. And frankly, way more dignified than gnawing jerky like a little alley cat.” He gestured grandly at his handiwork, as if unveiling a masterpiece.

Snowy blinked at the bowl. Then at Phainon. Then back at the bowl. And then, very deliberately, he pushed the bowl an inch away with his paw.

Phainon squinted. “Don’t you dare.”

Snowy pushed it another inch.

“Unbelievable,” Phainon muttered, throwing his hands up. “Hours of labor. Chopping. Seasoning. Pouring my soul into the broth—and you look at it like I just handed you poison.” He jabbed a finger toward the cupboard. “All you ever want is jerky. Jerky, jerky, jerky. Do you think I’m raising a wolf? A picky wolf-child? Because that’s what it feels like.”

Snowy licked his lips, not even pretending to be sorry.

Phainon groaned, dragging the rejected bowl back toward himself. He plopped down opposite Snowy weary. “Fine. More for me, I guess.” He scooped up a spoonful, blew on it, and took a long sip—only to sigh, half-amused. “And it’s not even bad, you know. It’s actually… good.” He gestured vaguely with his spoon, looking mournful. “But apparently that doesn’t matter, because I’m raising the most ungrateful chimera alive.”

Snowy tilted his head.

Phainon stabbed at another piece of potato, sulking. “Just one bite,” he said, softer now, leaning forward a little. “C’mon. For me? Please??”

He looked at Snowy with the wide, exasperated eyes of a man begging a toddler to eat their vegetables.

Snowy stared down at the stew for a long, silent moment. For a second, Phainon thought he’d won—that maybe guilt or pity or sheer curiosity would override that stubborn streak.

And then, to his shock, Snowy leaned forward.

Phainon straightened in his seat instantly, excitement flaring so fast it nearly made him drop his spoon. “Wait, hold on—don’t move. I’ve got it.” He dipped the spoon carefully into the broth, making sure to catch a bit of everything—potato, carrot, a sliver of meat—and blew on it until the steam stopped curling. He even tested it against his wrist before nodding in approval. “Alright. Perfect. Open up.”

He held the spoon out like he was feeding royalty.

Snowy, to his eternal credit, didn’t make it easy. He eyed the spoon with suspicion, but after a beat, he leaned in, lips twitching before finally lapping at the broth and swallowing it down in one go.

The silence that followed was heavy, expectant. Phainon’s grin hung on the edge of his face, desperate but afraid to spook the moment.

Snowy blinked once. Slowly. His ears flicked back, and then—

“…hmp.”

It was tiny. Barely even a sound. More a grunt than a word. But it was *something*.

Phainon nearly rocketed out of his chair. He threw his fist in the air with a bark of laughter, victory shining in his eyes. “Yes! I knew it! I *knew* you’d like it!” His smile broke wide, sunlight spilling across his face as though the world had just tilted in his favor. “See? What did I tell you? Balanced. Nutritious. Delicious!”

Snowy tried to retreat, but Phainon was already shoving the bowl closer, spoon at the ready, his enthusiasm boundless. “Here, here—don’t be shy now. Eat all of it. I don’t want you starving on my watch.”

And then the petting started. He ruffled Snowy’s ears, scratched gently along his jawline, rubbing the fur like he couldn’t decide whether to reward or smother him. “Good boy,” he crooned, voice fond and far too pleased with himself. “My picky little chimera finally ate something. Look at you. I could cry.”

Snowy huffed and looked away, but he didn’t pull back from the petting. Which, for Phainon, was all the permission he needed to keep going, grinning like a fool the whole while.

He sat there like a proud parent, chin propped in one hand, the other absentmindedly carding through Snowy’s fur. Every bite was met with an automatic murmur of praise.

“Not so bad, right? You’re tougher than you look. My brave little chimera.” His grin tugged wider as he ruffled Snowy’s ears. “Can’t believe I actually got you to eat stew...”

He rambled on while Snowy lapped dutifully, recounting the day in no particular order. “Had to restock the pantry this morning, ran into half the city while I was at it. Then someone cornered me about helping with training drills… and whilst helping Alexander—” His words slowed, a pause slipping between them. His head snapped up. “Shit.”

The chair scraped as he shot upright. Snowy blinked at him, stew still halfway swallowed, as Phainon pressed a hand to his forehead. “Crap, crap—I’m late. I promised Alexander I’d spar with him today. Completely slipped my mind.”

He turned toward the door, then hesitated, something tugging him back. With a sigh, he bent down and planted a firm kiss right between Snowy’s ears. “Don’t give me that look,” he muttered, cheeks warming. “It’s good luck.”

He straightened, faltered, then groaned as Snowy gave the tiniest, squirmiest shuffle. “Ugh, damn it,” he said, bending down again for a second smooch. “Too cute for your own good.” Only then did he finally straighten, tugging at his shirt. “Alright, I’m serious this time. I’ll be back in a few hours, don’t miss me too much!”

One hand ran through his hair as he muttered about Alexander under his breath, trying to tame the mess of strands. “He’s been pestering me all week. Can’t put it off again, otherwise I’ll never hear the end of it. You’d think with how shy he was the first week, he’d stay that way. But no—persistent as hell. Bold as brass.” Phainon chuckled to himself. “Suppose it’s flattering a young man like that feels so at ease with me.”

He crouched to grab his boots—only to stop dead.

Snowy was perched squarely on his coat.

“…Excuse me?” Phainon blinked.

Snowy didn’t twitch. Didn’t even blink.

Concern hit first. He hurried over and scooped the chimera up carefully so he wouldn’t slip. “Careful! You can’t just wedge yourself in like that, you’ll fall—” His words faltered as he caught the look on Snowy’s face.

Phainon sighed, lips twitching. “…Really? This is what we’re doing now?”

Snowy just stared, unyielding.

His chest tightened despite himself, but he set Snowy down gently. “Look. I can’t just stay, alright? I promised him. And when Mydei comes back—what then? I’ll spar with him too. I can’t just cancel every time someone needs me.” His tone tried for firm, even as his hand hovered too long on Snowy’s back.

“You don’t even know Alexander,” he continued, exasperated. “He’s fine. He’s—”

A low, unmistakable growl rolled from Snowy’s throat.

Phainon froze. “…Did you just—*growl* at me?”

The grumble came again, louder.

“Oh my god.” His eyebrows shot up, then a laugh cracked out of him. “You’re actually jealous. My chimera’s jealous of my sparring partner.” He dragged a hand down his face before collapsing back into his chair, ruffling his hair further into a mess.

“Snowy, listen.” His voice was patient but firm. “I don’t back out of promises. Alexander’s not competition—he’s just someone to hit. That’s it. No reason for you to—”

The rest caught in his throat.

Snowy’s ears had drooped. His tail curled tight around Phainon’s leg. His eyes—light, huge, shimmering—locked on him with the most devastating, deliberate puppy-eyed stare imaginable. A soft, trembly whine slipped out.

Phainon froze mid-motion, hand hanging helplessly in the air. His breath stalled. “…Snowy?”

The chimera didn’t budge. If anything, he pressed closer, trembling faintly.

The fight bled out of Phainon all at once. He sighed, stroking Snowy’s back with slow, tender motions.

Snowy leaned harder, stubborn in his smallness.

“…Okay, fine,” Phainon muttered, defeated. “One more hour. Just one more.”

The satisfaction radiating off Snowy was instant, though he buried it by tucking into Phainon’s neck like it wasn’t obvious.

Phainon narrowed his eyes at the halfhearted restraint. “You little cheat.” Fondness undercut every word. He wrapped both arms around Snowy, hauling him fully against his chest despite the squirm. “Might as well commit if you’re pulling this stunt.”

He buried his face into soft fur, petting with an almost aggressive fondness. “There. Now you’re stuck. Hope you’re happy, you cunning little fluffball.”

Snowy sighed, finally settling.

Phainon smiled into his fur, content against all reason.

It was finally the day.

Phainon had told himself it wasn’t a big deal—because it wasn’t. Mydei had gone on missions alone plenty of times before. This wasn’t new. He wasn’t going to make a fool of himself by waiting at the gates like some overeager puppy, glowing like he hadn’t had a minor panic spiral in front of a chimera. No. He had dignity. He could play it cool.

…Mostly.

He’d been pacing the Plaza for the better part of an hour, hands clasped behind his back, doing laps like a man training for some invisible marathon. Circle the fountain, glance at a stall, double back again. People had started giving him looks. He ignored them.

The one constant in his orbit was Snowy—shadowing him so close it was like he’d sprouted a second shadow. Every turn, every pause, there the chimera was, practically tripping his heels.

Phainon stopped mid-step, glanced down at him. “What, you nervous too? Or trying to herd me like a sheepdog?”

Snowy flicked his tongue.

Phainon raised a brow. “Don’t think I won’t get the staff involved. Impersonating livestock is a punishable offense.”

Snowy’s stare did not waver.

He sighed, a hint of laughter in it. “Fine. Come here, then.” With practiced ease, he scooped Snowy up, tucking him against his chest. “Let’s get some air. Maybe a better view will calm you down. Or me. Whichever.”

Snowy gave the smallest pout but didn’t resist when Phainon vaulted onto a nearby awning, then climbed to a higher ledge, until finally he perched on the broad rooftop overlooking Okhema. From here, the city stretched out in neat lines and bustle, the gates visible in the distance.

Phainon settled down cross-legged, setting Snowy on his lap. The chimera immediately claimed the spot, curling in like it had been reserved.

“See? Much better,” Phainon murmured, leaning back on his palms. “We wait here. Less humiliating than hovering at the entrance like some—” He cut himself off, mouth quirking. “Well. Like some lovesick fool.”

Snowy tilted his head up at him.

“What?” Phainon asked, straight-faced. “I’m perfectly composed. Dignified. Entirely calm.” A pause. “…You don’t believe me.”

Snowy’s soft chuff was answer enough.

“Mm. Treasonous little beast,” Phainon muttered, though his hand had already found Snowy’s fur, stroking idly down his back. “I feed you, I let you bully me into eating jerky for three days straight, and in return you question my honor? Scandalous.”

Snowy shifted, burrowing deeper into his lap.

Phainon exhaled a laugh, fingers brushing a tuft of fur smooth. “Thought so. Can’t stay mad at you, hm? You’re lucky I have a weakness for clingy, jealous little chimeras.” He said it lightly, almost distracted. “Otherwise I’d be very cross with you.”

The city clattered on below, carts rattling, vendors shouting. Up here, though, it was just the two of them—Snowy curled warm against him, and Phainon waiting, gaze fixed on the far gates with an expression he’d swear to anyone was casual.

The sound almost managed to lull him into something resembling calm.

Almost.

A prickle crept along the back of his neck, subtle but unmistakable.

Phainon kept his eyes trained on the horizon, posture as steady as if nothing at all had shifted. Only the faint exhale through his nose betrayed him, and with it came the quiet repositioning of his arm. Snowy was drawn closer, tucked firmly against him, the spread of his palm over the chimera’s side more protective than restraining.

“Easy,” he murmured. His thumb stroked through fur in a soothing line. “I’ve got you.”

Snowy moved—ears flicking, tail giving an irritated lash—but Phainon’s hand steadied him again before he could stir too much. Outwardly, his expression didn’t change. Yet the breath he drew in carried an edge that hadn’t been there before.

“Now…” His voice, when it came, was still calm, but sharpened just enough to cut. “Lady Cipher. As much as I understand your taste for this type of entertainment, I’d appreciate if you didn’t test them on me tonight. I’ve no patience for games.”

A pause stretched long enough to make the air feel heavier. Then, at his left, the rooftop shimmered—and laughter spilled out like someone slipping off a mask they hadn’t bothered to wear properly in the first place.

“‘Lady?’” Cipher echoed, suddenly perched against the edge of the roof as though she’d been lounging there all along. The grin she shot him was bright and shameless. “Please. You’re making me sound respectable. Loosen up, Deliverer—I was just saying hello to your little lap ornament.”

She wagged her fingers in Snowy’s direction. The chimera immediately let out a low growl from the safety of Phainon’s lap.

Cipher’s grin only widened. “Aw, see? He likes me.”

Phainon’s hand never faltered as it stroked Snowy’s fur once more. His reply was flat but not unkind. “Your definition of ‘like’ concerns me.”

She laughed at that, tilting her head, entirely unbothered by the rebuke. “Don’t be so stiff. If I wanted to snatch him, you wouldn’t even know I’d done it.”

At that, Phainon finally turned to look at her. Now usually he’d be nicer, but with Snowy involved? “And yet you announce it out loud.”

Cipher’s smile only grew, teeth flashing. “Well, what can I say? Where’s the fun if you don’t know?”

She stretched like a cat in a sunbeam, hands laced behind her head, and squinted at the drifting clouds.

“Really, Deliverer,” she drawled, tilting her head toward him without bothering to sit up. “You’re holding him like he’s porcelain. Are you sure that’s not your boyfriend in there?”

Phainon’s jaw tightened, but his expression stayed composed. “I don’t know what you mean,” he replied evenly. But his brows knit, just enough to betray the confusion he tried to suppress.

Snowy pressed closer into his lap, ears pinned flat, his golden eyes locked on Cipher. Phainon smoothed a hand over his head, murmuring with a dry edge, “See? He senses your mischief. Don’t encourage it.”

Cipher chuckled low in her throat and flicked a pebble from the rooftop, watching it arc lazily into the plaza below. She hummed a tune off-key, tapping her fingers on her knee, the very picture of idleness—except for the sly glint in her gaze when she slid her eyes back to them. “Scheming? Me?” she said innocently. “Perish the thought. I’m only here enjoying the view.”

“You’re circling him,” Phainon said humming. “Try not to act so much like a hawk over prey.”

That earned a sharp bark of laughter. She rolled onto her stomach, propping her chin on her fists as she leaned closer. “Oh? And what’s this little predator doing, then?” she teased, reaching out with mock affection. Snowy answered with a sudden snap of his teeth, the sound sharp in the air.

Cipher’s grin widened like a child who’d just been handed a new toy. “Feisty,” she purred. “I like him.”

Phainon sighed, rubbing behind Snowy’s ears to soothe him. “He’s better behaved than this usually,” he said, half exasperated, half amused—as though the irony weren’t lost on him that this was how Snowy chose to misbehave.

Cipher leaned back again, arms folded behind her head, all lazy composure. “He’s not misbehaving,” she said airily. “He’s hungry. That’s all.”

Phainon’s frown deepened. He glanced down at Snowy, who was still glaring with tense focus. “Hungry? Strange… I just fed him.”

With a theatrical flourish, Cipher produced something from thin air—or perhaps from a pocket no one had noticed. It gleamed strangely, metallic in the sun, too shiny to be normal food. She pinched it between her fingers, holding it out under Snowy’s nose with a wicked grin.

Phainon’s hand immediately swept in front of Snowy. “No. He doesn’t eat just anything. He’s picky enough with what I make as it is. And besides, I told you—he just ate.”

Snowy lunged suddenly, teeth grazing Phainon’s sleeve in his haste. Phainon jerked back, eyes flashing wide. “What—! Snowy, what has gotten into you?”

Cipher’s laughter rang out bright. “Oh, come now, Deliverer. Don’t look so scandalized. Even the pickiest eater has their weakness. Just let him have it.”

Her grin turned sharper as she waggled the treat again, waving it under Snowy’s nose like a dangling lure. “I promise—this one, he won’t refuse.”

“You can’t just feed strange things to someone else’s companion,” Phainon said firmly, leaning protectively over Snowy, his hand braced against the chimera’s chest.

“Relax.” Cipher shrugged, her voice sing-song but her eyes too sharp to match the carelessness. “It’s harmless. Just a snack. You really think I’d kill your precious pet?”

“No—” Phainon started.

Snowy snapped again, this time more desperate, more eager. And before Phainon could stop him, he snatched the morsel straight from Cipher’s fingers.

For a moment, silence. Then Phainon pressed his hand to his temple with a long sigh, defeated. “Very well. But if he gets sick, I’ll hold you personally responsible.”

Cipher only smirked, leaning back on her elbows. “I’ll take my chances. Enjoy him while you can, Deliverer.”

Phainon glanced down at Snowy, who chewed the gleaming treat with rapt delight, as though it were the best meal he’d ever had. “Impossible,” he muttered, though his hand still stroked the chimera’s fur with absent fondness.

To say Mydei made an appearance that afternoon would be a lie. Phainon stood under the sun until even the tile beneath his boots baked hot, the sky glaring down unrelenting. Hours passed. Nothing. No sign.

Snowy, curled in his arms, shifted restlessly, his body running hotter than it should. Phainon frowned, brushing damp hair from his temple as he adjusted his grip on the chimera. “Strange,” he muttered. “You’ve never minded the heat before.”

Snowy gave a faint growl, but it came out more like a weak whimper. He pressed closer, his body almost searing to the touch. Phainon adjusted him again, concern pricking sharper now.

(If only he knew—the little glimmer of Cipher’s handiwork had already begun to work its way through.)

By now, he should have gone to Aglaea. She always knew where to find Mydei, or at least had the right strings to tug. Truthfully, he was ready to set out himself, to comb the city stone by stone until he found the man. He had half a mind to do it—until his fingers brushed against his inner pocket.

There it was. A slip of parchment, folded twice over.

Patience, Deliverer. Your Prince Charming will be back in a few hours. You might want somewhere private for the reunion—unless you prefer an audience?

-Cipher

Phainon huffed. He couldn’t stay in his own quarters—he’d feel caged, pacing walls too narrow for the hours stretching ahead. And Snowy—burning as he was—needed more than stone and silence.

So he went to the one place that made sense.

Mydei’s residence.

How? He had a key. A key Mydei had pressed into his hand with a nod and a don’t lose it. Why Mydei had given it—Phainon had no idea. He’d never

dared to ask.

Now, the door clicked open with a sound that felt far too intimate.

He should’ve sat. Instead, he paced, his boots moving grooves into the rug, his shoulders tense beneath his robes. Snowy, on the other hand, sprawled unceremoniously across the bed like he owned the place, the blankets bunching beneath his restless heat.

“You,” Phainon muttered, finally stopping long enough to lay the back of his hand against Snowy’s fur again, wincing at the warmth pulsing through. “You’re hotter than the sun itself.”

Snowy flicked an ear, the chimera equivalent of a stubborn glare, then huffed again, curling deeper into the pillows as if that solved everything.

Phainon sighed, stripping his outer layer of robes and fanning the air uselessly. “Of all times to burn like a forge,” he said, tone half-worried, half-exasperated. “You could’ve picked another season.”

Snowy answered with a glare.

Phainon dragged a hand down his face, then sat on the edge of the bed, restless knee bouncing. He leaned back, looking up at the ceiling with an exhale that refused to leave his chest. “If Cipher’s note was another trick…” he murmured, “then I swear—”

Snowy made a small sound, cutting him off—something oddly plaintive.

That alone silenced him.

He turned, softer this time, brushing Snowy’s fur with a gentler hand. “All right. Easy now. I’m here. Just… hold out a little longer, hm?”

Luckily, after barging into Mydei’s home and raiding every cupboard, Phainon found what he needed—a basin, a cloth, and water cold enough to sting his fingers. He wrung the towel out until it dripped, then laid it carefully across Snowy’s back.

The chimera twitched at first, tail flicking in protest, but gradually relaxed, the unnatural heat ebbing. Phainon didn't dare look away, trading cloths as soon as they grew warm, hovering with the single-minded focus.

By the time an hour had passed, Snowy was finally cooling. His breaths evened out, no longer labored, his fur damp but less feverish to the touch.

"Thank the gods…" Phainon exhaled so hard his shoulders dropped. He slumped forward against the edge of the mattress, forehead resting there for a moment like all the tension was finally leaking out of him.

When he straightened again, brushing damp strands of hair from his face, his lips curved faintly upward. "…Well. Now that's over with…"

Snowy cracked an eye open at him.

"Oh, don't look at me like that," Phainon muttered, then tapped his chin as if struck by a thought. "Actually, you know what? I've realized something." His mouth quirked. "I've spent all this time with you, but I don't know what you sound like when you're not growling or hissing. At least meow once so I know what sound files I'm working with."

Snowy's ear twitched. That was it.

"…Not even a squeak? A chirp?" Phainon tried again, leaning closer. "A whistle? A honk?"

Nothing.

Snowy rolled his face away from him.

Phainon let out a long-suffering sigh and flopped forward in defeat. "You're crueler than your master."

Still, he couldn't resist climbing onto the bed, sprawling beside Snowy until they were face to face. He braced his head against one palm, body angled toward him with a half-smile. "…Fine, whatever. I'll stop bothering you."

Snowy gave one smug look, the picture of victory.

For a few minutes, the quiet was companionable. But as the silence of Mydei's empty home stretched on, the corners of Phainon's good mood began to crumble. He sighed again—loudly, the tenth time today.

"…You mind if I overshare?" he asked the chimera softly.

Snowy made a weak, muffled grumble.

"I knew I could count on you," Phainon said with a faint smile, then stared at the ceiling.

His voice started sharp, irritation dripping into every word: "Honestly, he should've been back hours ago. And when he finally does, I should give him an earful…" He tugged at his collar, scowling. "Though—gods. If he walked through that door right now, I'd probably let him do whatever he wants, as long as he's safe."

He didn't even realize his words were softening until they already had.

"Stelle told me that meant I'd… what was it…" His brow furrowed as he muttered. "…'Let him hit'—"

The sentence died halfway out of his mouth. His lips pressed together.

"…Never mind."

Silence.

It took him two whole seconds to realize what he'd said. His head snapped toward Snowy. "…I didn't mean it like that," he blurted quickly.

Snowy didn't dignify him with eye contact. The chimera simply angled his ears back, tail moving in a rhythm that screamed judgment.

Heat crawled up Phainon's neck. "Oh, come on. Don't give me that look. It's not—" He coughed, rubbing awkwardly at the back of his neck. "… Anyway. Forget it. I didn't—"

Snowy's tail flicked harder.

Phainon groaned, throwing an arm over his face. “Great. Now even you think I’m pathetic.”

Snowy still wouldn’t look at him.

“Fine. Fine. I’m sorry, alright? I didn’t mean to—” His palm brushed Snowy’s fur again. He froze. “…Wait. Hold on—*are you burning up again!?*”

Snowy squirmed weakly, a soundless little noise leaving him. Phainon mistook it instantly for pain and gathered him up into his arms without hesitation. “Don’t fight me, I’ve got you,” he murmured, cradling the chimera. His brows furrowed tight with worry, his every muscle tense.

He sat there for a long stretch, fussing, pacing back and forth at the edge of the bed with Snowy in his arms, muttering half-coherent reassurances. Then, all at once, it dawned on him: Snowy’s heat wasn’t climbing anymore. In fact, he seemed steady. Relaxed.

Wait. Instead of a fever this time… was he just flustered?

Phainon froze, blinked twice—then laughed aloud, incredulous. “Hah! Sure, fine—laugh it up. I’m embarrassing, I know.” He sighed, letting his forehead tip forward until it brushed Snowy’s fur. “But as long as you’re alright, I don’t care.”

Snowy gave the faintest flick of his paw. Phainon took it as permission to keep holding him.

He adjusted his grip, scooping Snowy up like a spoiled housecat as he rose to his feet. With careful steps, he wandered toward the window, clutching him close. The world outside greeted him in bright colors—the sky clear, clouds lazily drifting, the courtyard below alive with the hum of a day untouched by his turmoil.

Phainon rested his chin against the crown of Snowy’s head, his voice low, almost wistful. “It’s a beautiful day, isn’t it?”

For a moment, there was peace. Warm sunlight across his shoulders. The quiet thrum of a heartbeat against his chest. The illusion of normalcy, the kind that made him forget anything had ever been strange.

Until Snowy stirred, writhing faintly. A pained noise left him, sharp enough to cut the calm. Phainon frowned immediately, pressing a soft kiss to the chimera's cheek, half instinct, half distraction as he whispered, "What's wrong now, hm? Talk to me—"

He didn't get to finish.

The world buckled beneath him—not from a misstep, not from clumsiness, but from a sudden weight. Heavy, undeniable, crashing down from above. His knees buckled. Balance ripped away.

"*—the hell!?*"

They toppled. The air split with a thud and the crackle of displaced energy. Smoke erupted around them in a choking cloud, the acrid tang of something sweet curling in his throat. Phainon hit the floor flat on his back, the breath knocked out of him, his skull just shy of cracking against the boards.

Instinct took over. His arms locked tighter around where Snowy was, shielding him. Muscles coiled, ready to strike, to roll, to drive his elbow into the ribs of whatever had just ambushed them.

"Snow—!" His voice cracked with raw panic—

And then he saw.

Not an enemy. Not a beast.

A man.

Golden eyes burned above him, sharp as forged metal and startlingly close. A mane of beige hair framed his face, bleeding into crimson at the edges like wildfire taking hold. Tattoos traced crimson arcs over sun-dark skin, coiling down arms roped with strength. His lips—full, breath parted, trembling—moved as if to speak but stopped.

And his face—handsome enough to disarm armies—was flushed. Red-streaked, unsteady, *embarrassed*.

Phainon's jaw unhinged. His mind went blank. His body forgot how to move. Why exactly? Because after a moment he realized, the fucking Crown Prince (King technically) of Castrum Kremnos—*Mydeimos*—was on top of him. Straddling him. Staring down at him with the rarest expression Phainon had ever seen: startled, cornered, human.

Time slowed. Smoke curled and dissolved. The silence pressed tighter and tighter, unbearably taut.

And then Mydei, resolute Mydei, fearless Mydei, opened his mouth.

"…Meow?"

Phainon's brain had stalled out somewhere between *golden eyes* and *uncharacteristically flushed*. Everything past that was just static, static, static. He wasn't mentally prepared to deal with this. Hell, he wasn't even spiritually equipped to process this.

And of course, his traitor mind decided now—right now—was the perfect moment to serve him a memory from years ago, back when he'd been a wide-eyed, naive kid in Aedes Elysiae. Back when he thought being a hero was just… saving people and looking good while doing it.

Cyrene had been with him that day, perched cross-legged on a low stone wall with her book laid across her lap. She'd been "babysitting" him in her own words, but in reality she was mostly doodling crude little monsters into her book while he pestered her with hypotheticals.

Now that he thinks about it, she may have been high at the time.

"What if a basilisk looks me in the eye?"
"Wear sunglasses."
"What if I'm outnumbered twenty to one?"
"Run faster than the slowest guy in your group."
"What if—" he'd paused, kicking a rock with all the solemnity of a child

trying to understand mortality, “—what if I’m faced with something so strong I don’t even *know* what to do?”

Cyrene had beamed at him, eyes bright, tone the cheeriest it had ever been as she proclaimed the age-old wisdom passed down by absolutely no one but herself:

“Easy, Phainon. Knock yourself the fuck out.”

At the time, he’d laughed so hard he nearly fell over. No way in a thousand years would that ever be real advice. *Who does that?*

…Apparently him.

Because staring up now at Mydei—lips parted just slightly like the gods themselves had sculpted temptation—Phainon felt his entire nervous system revolt. His thoughts dissolved into white noise. His instincts shrieked at him to *do something.*

So he did the most natural thing in the world.

He lifted his head, smooth and graceful despite the chaos in his chest, and kept his golden eyes locked unblinking on Mydei’s. A dazed smile tugged at his lips, serene and unhinged all at once.

“Mydei, my guy,” he said faintly, voice thin with awe and delirium, “you’re just… too much.”

And then, without hesitation, he let his head fall back down. Violently.

The crack against the floor was sharp, echoing. A sting of pain bloomed, warm trickles of golden blood threading instantly through his hair.

Mydei’s face went from shocked to alarmed so fast it almost blurred.

Phainon, dimly aware that one knock probably wasn’t enough to do the job, twitched like he might go for round two. But before he could slam his skull again, strong hands caught his shoulders, holding him firmly in place.

“What are you—?!” Mydei’s voice cracked, horror plain as his eyes darted to the blood. “Deliv—*stop!*”

Phainon blinked up at him, half-lidded and dizzy, and thought with the kind of calm clarity only head trauma could grant: *Nice. She was right.*

Then the world went blissfully black.

The last thing he saw was Mydei’s mouth open mid-curse, panic etched across every line of his perfect face as he shouted his name:

“What the fuck, Phain—”

And then nothing.

The next time Phainon woke, the world didn’t so much return as drip back into him in reluctant droplets.

First came the smell. Acrid, sterile, and aggressively clean. Antiseptic. It crawled into his sinuses like an uninvited guest, stinging until he had no choice but to scrunch his nose. His throat cracked dry when he muttered, voice hoarse and gravelly:

“Gods above, who spilled an entire vat of bleach in here…?”

Second: the ceiling. He pried one eye open and immediately regretted it, but not before the image seared into his brain— endless white tiles, arranged in a grid of soul-crushing monotony. Each one freckled with pointless little dots, like some architect’s idea of whimsy was to make patients imagine seasoning their food.

“…Perfect,” he croaked.

Third: the blanket. He tried shifting his arms and discovered he could barely move. The sheets were tucked so tightly around him it felt like the mattress had swallowed him whole. He wiggled uselessly, shoulders straining, jaw clenched.

“Who—” he hissed, “—who tucked me in like a corpse? Was this necessary? What if I had to… defend myself? Or breathe? What if I wanted to itch my nose? Ever think about that?”

The sheets did not answer.

Grumbling, he decided to fight back in the only way he could think of: by sitting up. A bold move. A disastrous move.

The moment his head left the pillow, agony detonated across his skull. The pain was so sharp and sudden it felt like someone had shoved a war drum inside his brain and was beating it with iron hammers. His stomach lurched, the room tilted violently sideways, and he slammed back down onto the pillow with a groan that was equal parts curse and surrender. Both hands flew to his head like he could hold it together by force alone.

“Bad idea, bad idea, *bad idea*,” he gasped, squeezing his eyes shut until the brightness behind them dimmed to something survivable.

It took him a long moment to realize there was something tight around his skull. Bandages. Layers of them, snug, scratchy. His fingertips skimmed the rough edges automatically, feeling the ridges of wrappings that pressed against bruised skin. A patch on the left side was especially stiff, the fabric crusted with what was unmistakably dried blood.

“…Wonderful,” he muttered, tone flatter than parchment left in the sun.

His body felt heavy, as if they had to drag themselves uphill through syrup to reach him. Concussion fog, he realized dimly. He was concussed. That explained the pounding, the nausea creeping at the edges of his stomach, the weird way his vision refused to stay in one place for too long. He rubbed gingerly at his temple, like maybe pressing would unscramble the blurriness in his brain.

“Right,” he mumbled to himself, words tumbling out half-coherent, as though talking it through might anchor him. “I was at Mydei’s place. With Snowy. Window was nice. Day was nice. Snowy was… not nice. Then…

weight. Smoke. Gold eyes. Red tattoos. And then—" he paused, lips pressing together, a faint grimace pulling at them. "Oh. Oh."

If anyone else were here, they'd probably judge him for talking to himself.

But alas, there was no one.

He slumped back, dragging one palm over his face. "And then I decided to follow Cyrene's age-old wisdom. 'Knock yourself out,' she says. Great advice. Brilliant. Inspired."

A dry laugh escaped him, immediately cut short when it jostled the throbbing in his head. He groaned again and let his arm flop uselessly onto the stiff hospital sheets.

His vision swam if he blinked too fast. His ears rang faintly with every heartbeat. His stomach tilted like it couldn't decide if it wanted to mutiny.

"…Yeah," he whispered, drifting, "definitely concussed."

Phainon should have gone back to sleep. That would've been the sensible thing. Close his eyes, let the throbbing lull him under again, and deal with everything later.

But of course, his brain—traitorous thing that it was—decided now was the perfect time to start *thinking*.

Too much time. Too many thoughts.

He exhaled slowly, staring at the pepper-speckled ceiling. *What exactly did I see before I blacked out?*

His hand slid up to press against the bandages as if squeezing them tighter might force out an answer.

"Okay," he was starting to talk to himself, "let's be rational about this. Step one. Was that real? Or a hallucination?"

A beat. His stomach flipped, not from nausea this time but from the *memory*.

“Oh no.” His voice cracked.

Because if it *wasn’t* a hallucination, then… then that meant…

“That means Snowy. *Snowy*. Turned into Mydei. And was straddling me.”

The words came out too loud in the quiet room. He immediately winced, as if the walls might judge him.

“Nope. Nope. Not thinking about that. Doesn’t matter. Not real. Totally hallucinated. Classic concussion symptom. Visual distortion. Common.” He nodded to himself a little too eagerly, then froze. But… but what if it *was* real?

The thought hit like a hammer to the chest.

Because if it *was* real, then how in all the gods’ names did Mydei turn into a chimera? And worse—worse—if Mydei *was* Snowy, then Phainon had very clearly and very dramatically declared his embarrassing, undying love for Mydei… directly to Mydei.

“Oh gods, oh gods, oh gods,” he groaned, dragging both hands down his face. The pain in his skull was nothing compared to the mortification creeping over every inch of him.

He kicked one leg under the too-tight sheets, wriggling like a trapped caterpillar, and finally gave in to the only defense mechanism left available.

Blanket. Over the head.

In one swift motion he yanked the stiff hospital sheet up to his chin, then over his nose, then all the way to his hairline until the world vanished into sterile-smelling darkness.

“Nope,” he mumbled into the fabric, voice muffled and pitiful. “Nope nope nope. Didn’t happen. Hallucination. Fever dream. Forget it. We’re

forgetting it.”

He curled onto his side as best the wrappings and sheets would allow, burying his face deeper until his own breath warmed the cotton.

If anyone walked in right now, they’d find nothing but a lump in a hospital bed, hiding from reality itself.

Phainon intended to stay that way until the universe got bored and left him alone.

But alas, hiding under a blanket forever was impossible.

So Phainon got another idea.

A *terrible* idea.

“Right,” he muttered, peeling the blanket off his face with the sluggish dignity of someone crawling out of their own grave. “If I can’t un-think it… I’ll just… leave. Yes. Escape. Genius.”

Step one: standing.

He rolled his legs off the bed with all the grace of a sack of potatoes, braced both hands on the mattress, and shoved himself upright. His feet hit the floor, knees wobbled—and for a glorious two seconds, he thought *hey, not so bad.*

Then his legs reminded him they were currently made of warm custard.

He staggered three heroic, flailing steps forward before catching himself against the bedpost, forehead thunking against the wood. The room tilted sideways, then upside down. He squeezed his eyes shut until the nausea ebbed.

“…okay,” he wheezed, patting the bedpost. “Walking: not ideal.”

Step two: improvisation.

His gaze fell on the squat wooden chair beside the bed. A perfect walking stick. He grabbed it with both hands, wobbling in triumph—then froze mid-lift.

“No, no, bad idea. Chairs are for sitting. Chairs are for dignity.”

He shoved it back down.

Step three: nourishment.

The food tray on the bedside table glowed like a beacon of hope. He shuffled closer and found… beige porridge. A whole steaming bowl of the stuff.

He sniffed it cautiously. Bland. Lifeless. Utterly unremarkable.

Still, he poked at it with the spoon, lifted a bite, and shoved it into his mouth. A second later he gagged softly and pushed the tray away.

Step four: the door.

The brass handle gleamed at the far side of the room.

He inched toward it, one hand sliding along the wall for balance, until he reached the door. He wrapped trembling fingers around the handle and twisted gently.

Click.

Locked.

Phainon frowned, tried again. Jiggle. Jiggle. Nothing.

He pressed his ear to the wood, holding his breath.

Voices.

Muffled but clear enough—two of them, maybe healers, maybe guards.

“…took quite a blow to the head…”

“…concussion, but stable now…”

“…His Highness wouldn’t leave until we got the bleeding under control—”

Phainon jerked back from the door like it had sprouted teeth. His pulse spiked so hard it hurt.

His Highness.

Mydei.

Shit.

That meant Mydei had been here. Sitting at his bedside.

His stomach lurched. His bandaged head throbbed. His pride keeled over and died.

“That’s it,” Phainon hissed under his breath, clutching his skull. “Nope. Not facing him. Not happening. I’m getting out before he shows up and—gods forbid—*talks to me*.”

Step five: the only option left.

He turned his head toward the window.

The pale curtains fluttered faintly with the draft. Sunlight spilled across the sill. Beyond that: rooftops, sky, freedom.

It was the dumbest plan he’d ever had. Which, tragically, made it the most appealing.

He drew a shaky, dramatic breath.

“Screw it,” he muttered, steeling himself. “Window it is.”

And with that, Phainon began the slow, dizzy, utterly ridiculous trek toward freedom.

When he finally reached the sill, Phainon clung to the frame and pressed his forehead against the cool glass. The pane kissed back a faint chill, grounding him in a way that felt almost conspiratorial.

He curled his fingers under the latch. With a cautious tug, the window gave a complaining creak—then swung open without resistance.

Phainon blinked at it, then let out a soft laugh that immediately stung his ribs.

"…Huh. That was almost too easy."

The curtains lifted in the draft, shifting around him in thin, whispering waves.

He leaned out far enough to look down—then outward.

Below, a respectable drop. Painful, sure, but survivable.

Across, another roof, close enough to leap if his legs weren't trembling with fatigue.

Not the first time he'd made a questionable jump in worse conditions. He'd been drunker. Dizzy. Once with a head wound.

He'd be fine.

With a grunt, he hauled himself up onto the sill. His ribs protested; he ignored them, planting both palms firmly against the stone to catch his balance. The room behind him looked maddeningly cozy, like a trap disguised as comfort. The sky beyond stretched vast, endless, and more inviting than any bed.

He swung one leg over, settling his toes against the ledge, steadying himself with a shaky inhale.

Halfway there.

Another breath. He could do this.

“See? Easy,” he murmured to no one but himself. “Just a little jump. Land, run, never see—”

Then the door creaked.

Soft. Careful.

The sound of a hand on the latch, turning slow, easing it open as if not to wake a sleeping body.

Phainon froze, one leg dangling into the open air, his head snapping toward the noise.

The door inched wider. A shadow eased into the room, stretching long across the floorboards.

“…Are you awake, Deliver—?”

The voice was quiet, cautious, every syllable laid down with the tenderness of someone afraid to intrude.

Phainon’s heart dropped hard into his stomach.

He hadn’t turned yet. He didn’t need to. The warmth in that tone was unmistakable.

For one suspended second, the room was held in softness—the prince lingering in the doorway, shoulders curved slightly as though he’d meant only to peek in, to check if Phainon was comfortable, if he needed anything. His presence filled the chamber without crowding it, the gentleness in his expression so at odds with everything Phainon had been preparing for.

Phainon almost convinced himself he could brazen it out. Pretend. Joke. Maybe Mydei would back out the way he came if he thought Phainon was asleep.

But then—

A rush of air.

The curtains snapped wild against the frame, the open window suddenly swallowed by something faster.

Hands seized his waist.

The strength behind them was terrifying in its ease. Phainon was plucked clean off the sill and hauled backward in a single, fluid motion, like he weighed no more than a cloak being gathered from a hook. His body collided against the heat of a chest he knew instantly, the solid wall of muscle and steadiness anchoring him whether he wanted it or not.

His breath caught in a startled choke. “What—?”

The grip didn’t loosen.

Twisting slightly, he craned his neck back—and found himself staring up at exactly who he’d hoped not to see.

Mydei.

He didn’t want to look at him. Didn’t want to see what expression waited there.

But he did.

And in that instant, the prince’s gentleness—so clear just moments ago in the doorway—was gone.

What replaced it was restraint wound razor-tight, anger pulled taut across every line of his face. His jaw set hard. His eyes, usually so steady, blazed with a furious clarity. Every inch of him radiated not irritation for its own sake, but frustration sharpened by concern: for Phainon specifically.

The difference was startling. Almost unbearable to look at.

“What is wrong with you.”

It wasn’t loud. It didn’t need to be.

The measured tone struck hotter than fire, the syllables curling through Phainon’s chest and leaving no room to laugh it off.

His throat bobbed. His pulse thundered. He couldn’t—wouldn’t—do this right now.

So, like any rational man staring down death in the shape of a furious Mydeimos, he tried the smallest, dumbest thing possible: easing sideways, wriggling with mock-nonchalance, as though he might simply slip free if he played casual enough.

Mydei’s hold answered before words did.

It tightened.

Not enough to cause pain—just firmly, irrevocably, enough to crush the very thought of escape in its cradle.

Slowly, Mydei guided Phainon away from the window. Phainon shuffled along, legs heavy and unreliable, the dizziness clinging to him stubborn as smoke.

“You make a terrible jailer,” he muttered, aiming for levity though his voice sounded thinner than he wanted. He craned his neck just enough to try to catch Mydei’s face. “Could’ve just asked nicely, you know. Something polite. ‘Dearest Deliver, would you mind not throwing yourself out a window today?’”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with an answer. Just that look—absolutely unimpressed, a quiet dismissal of his jokes.

Phainon winced.

Finally, Mydei exhaled through his nose, sighing. “Would you have listened?”

For a moment, Phainon almost laughed. The corner of his mouth quirked instead. “I’d like to think so. I’m very reasonable you know.”

When they reached the bed , Mydei pressed him down—not violent, but firm enough that Phainon’s knees gave in with a grunt. He fell back onto the mattress, letting out a half-muffled laugh at the indignity of being manhandled like a stubborn child.

He wriggled to get comfortable, tugged at the blanket, then started tapping his fingers restlessly against his thighs. Anything to keep his eyes busy. Anything to avoid the steady weight of Mydei’s gaze.

The silence stretched.

“Why did you think escaping like that was a good idea?” Mydei asked at last, his voice edged with sternness. “And the head thing—were you honestly trying to knock yourself out or was there something else? Tell me, Deliverer. Are you actually that stupid?”

Phainon chuckled weakly. “Not stupid,” he said, though his voice faltered like it couldn’t quite commit. He shifted, tugging the blanket higher, curling into the weight of the bed. His laugh caught in his throat. “Just… inventive.”

Mydei didn’t look convinced. He leaned slightly forward, obviously about to get to the point.

“…Don’t. Please,” Phainon whispered, the levity slipping at last. He stared at the folds of the blanket, his voice catching.

Mydei tilted his head. “Don’t what?”

Phainon exhaled shakily, then glanced away. “Don’t press me about what I said earlier. Not right now.” The words spilled out faster than he meant them to, and he rushed to tack on before Mydei misunderstood, “I’m not dodging it! I promise. We’ll talk about it—really talk about it. Just…” His fingers tapped faster on his thigh. “Not now. My head’s still foggy. And you —” he swallowed, forcing himself to look briefly at Mydei before glancing

away again “—you deserve an actual conversation. Not whatever garbled nonsense I’d spit out like this.”

The embarrassment in his voice gave it a rough edge, but the sincerity beneath it was impossible to miss.

He tugged the blanket again, then softened, speaking quieter. “Please? Let me… let me give you the kind of answer you deserve. Not the half-mangled one I’d give while my brain’s trying to leak out my ears.”

The silence returned, but it didn’t feel empty. Mydei studied him for a moment. Phainon’s fingers drummed against his thighs like a heartbeat, waiting.

Finally, Mydei’s hand came to rest against his shoulder. Not holding, just a touch that grounded. His expression softened, and after a pause, he nodded once.

“Alright. I’ll wait.”

No pressure or conditions added on. Just patience.

Phainon felt something unclench in his chest, a weight he hadn’t realized he’d been dragging. Mydei’s voice always carried a sort of calmness. Somehow, it always managed to soothe Phainon.

Exhaustion crept back in, dragging heavy at Phainon’s limbs. He fought it stubbornly, smirking faintly as his head lolled against the pillow.

Mydei, of course, noticed. “Lay down properly, HKS,” he murmured, eye twitching. “You’re making a mess of it.”

Phainon closed one eye lazily. “Bossy,” he muttered, but the smirk stayed.

A moment of quiet passed, soft enough that Phainon thought maybe Mydei would leave it there. But then his voice came again, deceptively casual:

“…Unless you’d like to explain who exactly this ‘Alexander’ is?”

Phainon groaned aloud this time and promptly shut his eyes as tight as possible, feigning sleep with all the dignity of a child pretending they couldn’t hear their name being called.

The silence that followed cracked only with the softest sound: a quiet snort of laughter. Mydei shifted closer, and a moment later Phainon felt the brush of fingers against his hair, sweeping it gently off his forehead.

“Go to sleep, HKS,” Mydei whispered, softer than the air between them. “I’ll see you tomorrow.”

The warmth of the words sank into him, and this time Phainon didn’t resist. Sleep pulled him down fully, the quiet wrapping around him like a promise.

With any luck, he’d survive facing Mydei when he woke.

Tomorrow would come soon enough.

End Notes

A bit rushed by the end but I hope you guys still liked it <33333

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